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Programme Design Committee

Prof. Uma Kanjilal (Chairperson)
Faculty of LIS, SOSS, IGNOU

Prof. B.K.Sen, Retired Scientist
NISCAIR, New Delhi

Prof. K.S. Raghavan, DRTC
Indian Statistical Institute, Bangalore

Prof. Krishan Kumar, Retired Professor
Dept. of LIS, University of Delhi, Delhi

Prof. M.M. Kashyap, Retired Professor
Dept. of LIS, University of Delhi, Delhi

Prof. R.Satyanarayana
Retired Professor, Faculty of LIS
SOSS, IGNOU, New Delhi

Dr. R. Sevukan (Former Faculty
Member) of LIS, SOSS
IGNOU, New Delhi

Prof. S.B. Ghosh, Retired Professor
Faculty of LIS, SOSS, IGNOU, New Delhi

Prof. T. Viswanathan, Retired Director
NISCAIR, New Delhi

Dr. Zuchamo Yanthan
Faculty of LIS, SOSS, IGNOU, New Delhi

Conveners:

Dr. Jaideep Sharma
Faculty of LIS, SOSS, IGNOU, New Delhi

Prof. Neena Talwar Kanungo
Faculty of LIS, SOSS, IGNOU, New Delhi

Programme Coordinators

Prof. Jaideep Sharma and Prof. Neena Talwar Kanungo

Course Coordinator

Prof. Neena Talwar Kanungo

Course Preparation Team

Unit No(s)	Unit Writer(s)	Course Editor
5	Professor B.K. Sen	Prof. Neena Talwar Kanungo
6	Dr. G. Mahesh	
7	Professor T.N. Rajan	

Internal Faculty

Prof. Neena Talwar Kanungo
Prof. Jaideep Sharma

Print Production

Mr. Manjit Singh
Section Officer (Pub.)
SOSS, IGNOU, New Delhi

Secretarial Assistance

Ms. Sunita Soni
SOSS, IGNOU

Cover Design

Ms. Ruchi Sethi
Web Designer
E Gyankosh, IGNOU

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BLOCK 2 NON-DOCUMENTARY SOURCES

Introduction

The theme of this Block is non-documentary sources of information i.e. humans, institutions, and media. Whenever we talk about sources of information we think only about books, periodicals, reports, etc. We fail to realise that humans, institutions, and media can be equally important sources of information in teaching, learning and research. These sources are close allies of documentary sources. In fact, documentary and non-documentary sources of information complement and supplement each other. This Block comprises of three units (5,6,7). **Unit 5** discusses humans as sources of information; **Unit 6** deals with institutions as sources of information; and **Unit 7** is about media as sources of information.

Unit 5 of this Block explains how human source is different from human resource. It categorises human sources into two major groups namely, core information professionals and peripheral information professionals. Under both the categories various types of information professionals are listed. This Unit further elaborates how these professionals generate information and act as sources of information. The last section of the Unit explains the usefulness of human beings as a source of information in writing the biography of a celebrity, preparing a report of an event, or conducting a survey.

In **Unit 6**, institution as an invaluable source of information has been discussed. This Unit elaborates the role of institutions and organisations at the international and national levels. It covers international agencies, governmental, non-governmental organisations, R&D organisations, academic institutions, press, museums, publishing houses, etc. It also describes information products and services, activities, programmes and policies, and publications of the different types of institutions. Institutions act as valuable sources of information for a distinct category of information seekers.

Unit 7 of this Block explains how media and media persons can also act as a source of information for the researchers. This Unit explains the positive and negative influences of mass media. The different components of mass media e.g. print media, radio broadcasting, television, recordings, films, etc. have been discussed at length. The Unit gives a bird's-eye view of the Indian mass media scenario and demonstrates how they act as a useful information source. The role of media persons as resource persons has also been highlighted.

UNIT 5 HUMANS AS SOURCES OF INFORMATION

Structure

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- 5.10 References and Further Reading

5.0 OBJECTIVES

After going through this Unit, you will be able to:

- differentiate between human source and human resource;
- describe the core information professionals, who are engaged in generation, gathering, processing, dissemination, and many other activities related to information;

- identify peripheral information professionals as group separate from the core information professionals; and
- explain the role of human sources in writing a biography of a celebrity, or a report on an event.

5.1 INTRODUCTION

Every sensible human being is a source of information. S/he may be a child of five or nonagenarian of ninety-five, a charming lady or an incorrigible bore, a famous cricketer or an infamous footballer, a dare devil adventurer or a cautious wayfarer, a blind musician or a deaf mathematician, a high profile professor or an illiterate person, and all others irrespective of caste, creed, religion, race, gender, etc. There are professionals like information generators, information gatherers, information processors, information recorders, information disseminators, information retrievers, and information technologists who earn their livelihood basing information or information related activities and products. There are others who do not pertain to information profession but acts as sources of information. In this Unit you will be able to see how information professionals as well as information non-professionals are acting as important sources of information.

5.2 HUMAN SOURCE VS. HUMAN RESOURCE

In the field of library and information science we have different types of sources of information such as documentary source, non-documentary source, printed source, non-printed source. All these sources harbour information, and information can be obtained from them whenever necessary. Similarly all sensible human beings also possess information, and usually deliver the same when needed. Thus they become ‘human source’ of information. As you can see human source is a term belonging to library and information science.

You must have heard about human resource development, we have even a Ministry of Human Resource Development. The term ‘human resources’ has been defined as (i) “the people that staff and operate an organization” (Tracey); and (ii) “the personnel employed in an organization” (<http://en.wiktionary.org>). The term belongs to the field of management as well as economics. According to the definition, all the staff engaged in a library is human resource. In this Unit we are considering not only library staff but also non-library staff who by virtue of their experience, qualification, expertise, and knowledge have become source of information.

Self Check Exercise

Note: i) Write your answer in the space given below.

ii) Check your answer with the answers given at the end of this Unit.

1) Differentiate between the concepts ‘human source’ and ‘human resource’.

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5.3 CORE INFORMATION PROFESSIONALS

By core information professionals we mean those professionals whose principal functions are to generate, gather, process, record, disseminate, retrieve information, and provide various types of information services. All these professionals are being described below as:

5.3.1 Information Generators

Researchers, inventors, innovators, discoverers, thinkers, authors, planners, policy makers, decision makers, judges are some examples of generators of information. All these people know in and out of the information they have generated and thus they become good sources of information. Let us see how they generate information.

A **researcher** surveys, observes, thinks, hypothesises, designs and conducts experiments, records the results, and finally draws conclusions. Sometimes s/he surveys, tabulates the data, analyses the tabulated data. All these give rise to new information.

After a great deal of hard work, sometimes lasting for a number of years, an **inventor** develops a new machine, equipment, tool or the like. S/he discloses her/his invention through a patent, which contains details of the invention. The inventor continuously strives to enhance the productivity and efficiency of the machine. The success in her/his attempts, needless to say, gives rise to new information.

An **astronomer** while scanning the night sky with her/his telescope may encounter a comet not seen before. The moment s/he informs the media about her/his finding, information generates and the world comes to know about it. A **doctor** while investigating a new epidemic may chance upon a new virus. Doubtless it will generate new information.

The thinking of **philosophers** over the ages has given birth to a large number of philosophical systems all over the world. Philosophers developed their views after a great deal of thinking and made that known to people helping in the generation of new information.

The output of an **author's** mind can be seen in a variety of forms like books, articles, paintings, drawings, sculptures, etc. In many cases an author gleans information from various sources, weaves them together, adds something from her/his own thinking, experimentation or experience and brings out a book or an article. The new information content of the book may vary widely. For example, Ranganathan's *Prolegomena to Library Classification* harboured a huge amount of new information when it appeared for the first time.

A reputed **industrialist** planning a new enterprise or a new product, a multinational giant planning to start a joint venture in a developing country, an internationally renowned athlete planning to build a modern stadium, etc. all these generate information the moment a particular plan is disclosed. Quite often these type of information figure in mass media – locally, nationally and even internationally.

The decisions made by the **head of a state**, prime minister, or others in top positions almost always generate information of national and international significance, the moment the decision is made known. The decisions of the top executives of reputed industrial houses, business concerns, institutions and organisations also generate information of significance.

5.3.2 Information Gatherers

Reporters, correspondents, detectives, spies, police, compilers, enumerators, etc. are information gatherers by profession. All these people receive training for the job they do. Of course, there are many others in the society who gather information for various purposes. For example, a student gathers information to enrich her/his knowledge, a lawyer gathers information from her/his client to defend her/his case, a doctor gathers information from her/his patient to diagnose the disease, etc. However, we shall discuss under this category only those personnel whose profession is to gather information.

You know that information is generated through human activities. Whatever may be the case, a **reporter** is to collect information depending on its importance and reports it to the press along with photographs and other associated materials if that is possible. One moral responsibility that lies with the reporter is that the information s/he passes on to the press for wider dissemination should be authentic to the best of her/his knowledge. To establish the authenticity of the report, s/he has to check and crosscheck the information from various vital sources. Suppose, due to police firing some persons have been injured. When the reporter reaches the spot, s/he is likely to get different figures from different persons as to the number of persons injured and different views as to the cause of firing. To establish the actual number of persons injured, s/he may have to go to the nearby doctors and hospital(s) where the persons have received first aid or have been admitted for treatment. S/he may also visit the concerned police station to ascertain the number of persons injured and the cause of firing. S/he may also interview the injured people themselves, the people present at the scene, local political leaders, and other reliable sources to build up her/his entire report. Hence, for the information of a particular incident, a reporter proves to be a very good source of information.

‘A **correspondent** is a person employed by a news agency, periodical, or the like, to gather, report or contribute news, articles, etc. regularly from a distant place’ (Urdang: 302). Broadcasting agencies like BBC and CNN also appoint correspondents. From the definition, it is clear that a correspondent is also a reporter who reports from a distant place, usually a foreign country.

One of the important areas of journalism is investigative journalism. Here the **investigative journalist** engages herself/himself in unearthing such information as smacks of malpractices and corruption in the government machinery or elsewhere. Obviously, to unearth the information, the journalist acts very cautiously and gleans information very secretly bit by bit to build up the whole story. The disclosure of the information many a time has got a far-reaching effect. The downfall of President Nixon was the outcome of investigative journalism.

Crime detection is considered as one of the most important activities of **police**. In bigger police establishments, there are specialised police personnel to investigate crimes.

For crime detection, the police have to gather information from a number of sources by using various means. If one of the accomplices is nabbed, then the police tries to extract information about others from her/him employing various methods including interrogation. Apart from criminals, they question many people in search of clues. In addition, blood stains, pieces of cloth, strands of hair, cigarette ends, footprints, finger prints, etc. act as valuable sources of information as they form evidence. Those who analyse the aforesaid items are called **forensic scientists**.

The registers maintained by the police contain valuable information on crimes. These registers are still found to be useful for ferreting out valuable information about our freedom fighters.

As it has been pointed out earlier, a **detective** is usually a member of the police force. Sometimes, they may belong to private detective agencies as well. Their job, however, remains more or less the same. A **spy** on the other hand is 'a person employed by a government to obtain secret information or intelligence about another country' (Urdang: 1274). Spies employ various means and methods including various gadgets such as eavesdropping devices [a device used for secretly listening to conversation] to obtain required information. Thus, a police officer, a spy, a detective, possesses a great deal of information about criminals of the area they serve.

5.3.3 Compilers

Bibliographers, lexicographers, encyclopaedists and reviewers stand prominently among the set of **compilers**. Compilers are also gatherers of information. Take for example, a bibliographer gathers the bibliographical details of documents of her/his interest from numerous sources. Once the details are collected, s/he prepares a standard entry for each of the items. The entries are then organised in a helpful sequence which may be alphabetically author-wise, subject-wise, or year-wise. Thus a bibliographer becomes knowledgeable about the subject pertaining to the bibliography, and the sources from where data can be gathered.

A **lexicographer** first gathers words, phrases, idioms, proverbs, etc. of a language from written as well as spoken sources and then records the meaning and other details of each and every item. In many cases, s/he has to consult experts to fix the meaning of a particular word or phrase. In some cases s/he is to use her/his own judgment to decide the meaning of a word. Apart from this, s/he has to do many jobs such as the derivation and definition of a word to give final shape to a dictionary. Thus, a lexicographer becomes an excellent source of information on dictionary compilation and master of words.

The job of an **encyclopaedist** is far more laborious and time consuming than that of a lexicographer since an encyclopaedia includes thousands of articles of lengths varying from a few lines to scores of pages. For writing each article, the encyclopaedist gathers information from numerous sources, goes through each and every item thoroughly, and then writes down the article for the encyclopaedia covering each and every aspect. Till the middle of twentieth century, in some cases a single person brought out a multi-volume encyclopaedia spending her/his whole life. For example, Nagendra Nath Basu brought out his magnum opus called *Vishwa Kosh* in Bengali as well as in Hindi, both in twenty volumes!

Nowadays multi-volume encyclopaedias are usually brought out by renowned publishers where hundreds of authors contribute articles. Encyclopaedists by virtue of their knowledge gained during their work turn into a mine of information.

In this context by the word '**reviewer**' we mean a professional who authors state-of-the-art reviews, critical reviews, etc. These reviews are totally different from book reviews and depict the overall development of a narrow subject during a particular period, say, one or two years. For this purpose s/he undertakes a thorough search of relevant literature and compiles a comprehensive bibliography. Thereafter, s/he procures the full-text and in some cases abstracts of the documents. Having gone through the documents and getting a clear-cut understanding of the topic s/he jots down the review. This job updates her/his knowledge and makes her/him an up-to-date source of information on the field.

For bringing out reference sources like yearbooks, directories, books of general knowledge, biographies, gazetteers, etc. the information is gathered by the **compilers** from diverse sources using various methods. For the compilation of some reference sources like *Directory of Scientific Research Institutions in India*, and *Who's Who* the information is gathered by mailing questionnaires. For other sources, information is usually gathered from primary and secondary sources. The compilers of these categories of publications also become experts in the respective areas.

During census, conducted once in ten years in India, you must have noticed that a person visits your house and fills up a questionnaire asking the head or any other responsible person of the family a number of questions about the family members, their age, qualifications, occupations, etc. These people are called **enumerators**. The information gathered by these people is then processed using powerful computers to generate census reports from various angles. The enumerator becomes a good source of information about the area s/he has covered.

5.3.4 Information Processors

Under this category we shall discuss editors and their varieties, and also the information technologists especially software specialists who write programs for data processing.

When books, articles, reports, etc. are received for publication, in many cases plenty of inconsistencies, inaccuracies, redundancies, incompleteness, etc. are observed. To give final shape to the writing, editorial process becomes essential.

The editor while going through the writing, corrects spelling mistakes, capitalisation errors, wrong use of articles, incorrect use of words and punctuation marks, errors in syntax and paraphrasing, removes superfluous sentences, verbose, repetitions and inconsistencies, and fills up omissions. In many cases, the writing is sent back to the author with the corrections and remarks to elicit the author's consent. At this stage the author generally conveys her/his consent with minor alterations and additions. The writing thus attains its final shape and is sent for composition.

In big publishing houses, there are different types of editors such as **technical editors**, **style editors**, **language editors**, and the **general editors**. A technical editor is one who edits technical information. Many publishing houses have got

their own style of printing. For example, you will find in *Reader's Digest* that the first letter of an article is always printed with a big font. The numbers occurring in a sentence are spelt out if it is from one to ten, and written with figures if they are beyond ten. Just see the sentence "...when cancer patients who lacked family support wrote about their illness for 20 minutes a day, they reported less stress for up to six months" (*Reader's Digest*:161). You may note that in the sentence twenty has been written as 20, and the other number as six. This is because 20 is greater than ten, hence it is written in figures, six is less than ten, hence it is written in words. This is the house style of *Reader's Digest*. The style editor has to ensure that the publication conforms to the style of the house. Language editors are responsible to ensure correctness of the writing from linguistic point of view. Sometime back *European Journal of Vascular and Endovascular Surgery* needed an English language editor for ensuring the grammatical quality of articles accepted for publication in the printed journal (Internet). A general editor looks after almost every aspect of editing. These editors are knowledgeable in the art of editing. Moreover, they know the subjects thoroughly well they are dealing with. For example, the editor of a newspaper is an expert on current affairs.

A **programmer** is a computer professional who writes programs for computers. The data inputted in a computer is processed by the computer following the program that has been loaded into the computer for the purpose. Suppose, a library intends to retrieve books by the title, author(s), collaborator(s), subject, series, place of publication and publisher from the computerised catalogue. Here, the programmer will have to write programs in such a way whereby the computer will be able to process the information to provide the required answer. A programmer is an expert in programming. However, s/he gathers a good bit of knowledge about the activity for which s/he has written the program.

The expertise, which various types of editors and programmers possess, makes them important sources of information in the areas of their specialisation.

5.3.5 Information Recorders

The author and the reporter in most cases are found to be the first recorder of information. Inscribers, engravers, scribes, calligraphers, printers, data entry operators, typists, stenographers, compositors, proofreaders, videographers, photographers, painters, sculptors, etc. are other professionals that belong to this category.

Recording of information through writing has been going on for thousands of years. The early man recorded information not with a set of letters as we do today, but with symbols and pictures. The famous cave pictures at Altamira in Spain and Lascaux in France daubed at least 20,000 years ago seem to convey some definite message such as "Send us more animals like these" [Odham's.41]. The oldest known writing found on clay tablets in Mesopotamia dates to 3,000 BC or earlier. They were the writings of Sumerians [Odham's 44]. Large number of seals found in Indus Valley also contains writings that date back to 2,000 BC or earlier.

In this category of professionals, all are sources of information relating to their activity and environment. However, some category of professionals, like printers, at times prove to be good sources of information. By virtue of their job they come in contact with many authors whereby they get acquainted with various

aspects of their personality, publications, lifestyles, etc. Thus, for biographers, printers become good sources of information. Take for example, wild life photographers. The area they cover for wild life photography is well known to them. They know the geography of the area as well as the various animals, plants, people, etc. found in the area.

All the recorders listed here may not be a good sources of information. An English typist or data entry operator can type a book say in Spanish language, because the script of both the languages is the same. But s/he won't know anything about the content of the Spanish book. Similarly a typist can easily type a book on nuclear physics without gaining practically any knowledge of the subject.

5.3.6 Information Disseminators

You can see a great variety of professionals in this category, and most of them are important sources of information. The professionals belonging to this category are: library professionals, documentalists, information officers, extension workers, publishers, representatives of firms, receptionists, consultants, marketing officers, broadcasting professionals, press professionals, advertisers, teachers, doctors, lawyers, and hawkers. In addition, all persons engaged in telecommunication activities are also indirectly related to information dissemination. All these people are knowledgeable about the activities they are involved in. Say, for example, a good reference librarian, knows thoroughly the collection of a library and the information contained in the books. As a result s/he can handle any query for information with ease.

Among the library professionals, a librarian, a reference librarian, compilers of accessions lists or documentation lists, etc. are the disseminators of information. **Librarians** disseminate information in various ways. All librarians compile a catalogue of books and other documents available in the library. Using the catalogue s/he tells inquirers what books by an author are available in the library, books available on a particular subject or pertaining to a series, whether a book with a particular title is available in the library, etc. Many librarians bring out accession list of the library concerned from time to time. This list informs users about the books added to the library during a particular time. A reference librarian answers many queries of the users using the library collection. Often s/he also informs where a particular book or periodical may be available which is not there in her/his library collection.

A **documentalist** involves herself/himself in a number of activities like acquisition, recording, processing of documents and dissemination of information by way of supplying photocopies, computerised outputs, translations, bibliographies, and providing current awareness and selective dissemination of information services. At times, they also provide reference service as well. All these activities make her/him a good source of information.

Information officers, etc. In certain institutions, documentalists are designated as information officers, information scientists, etc. and they perform the same job as documentalists. However, in most cases, information officers are encountered in information centres/bureaus, enquiry offices, etc. of government ministries and departments. Many of our state governments like Maharashtra and Andhra Pradesh have their respective information centres in Delhi. Sometimes these units are called Public Relations Office or Reception and the officer

shouldering the responsibility of the office is called Public Relations Officer (PRO) or Receptionist. In various districts of our country, we have district information centres. Whatever may be the designation, the basic fact is that they are important sources of information and answer various queries posed by the public or any other person. Let us take a few examples.

A person sitting at the railway enquiry counter is a potential source of information as to the arrival and departure of various trains, fare between stations, and availability of seats/berths on a particular day at a particular train, etc. In big railway stations, the information about the arrival and departure of trains is updated almost every minute throughout the day.

The Information Officer of a State Information Centre provides information about business opportunities, educational facilities, important personages, tourism attractions, etc. of a state. In many cases they also supply a booklet usually containing a map of the state and description of important places, industry, sight-seeing places, etc.

A District Information Officer may provide you a booklet containing fairly good information about the district. S/he may also tell you about the facilities the district authorities can provide for the starting of an industry, a business, and so on.

A well dressed smart person sitting at the Reception Counter of a renowned hotel provides information to potential guests as to the availability of room/s and various other services provided by the hotel and the respective charges thereof through phone, e-mail, fax, etc.

The PRO of the Ministry of External Affairs is there to enlighten you about the various formalities to be fulfilled for obtaining a new passport, renewing an old one, etc.

Only a glimpse is being provided here about the plethora of information supplied by various information officers and their subordinates. The importance of these personnel as sources of information need not be overemphasised. You can well imagine the number and variety of persons engaged in the job and the type of information they are disseminating.

Extension Workers: We have not yet been able to eradicate illiteracy completely from our country. Still a large percentage of people cannot read or write. The number of such people is more in rural areas compared to urban areas. Print material will not be appropriate for imparting knowledge on healthy living, better methods of farming, low-cost housing, benefits and multiple methods of family planning to a large number of illiterate people. They can be taught all these to a certain extent through radio and television (TV) broadcasting. Unfortunately, many in our country, especially those living in the rural areas, cannot afford a radio set or a TV. As a result, the only option left to us is to deploy extension workers in the rural areas. Using lecture-and-demonstration method, they have been educating our rural folk for decades now. Carrying the message of high-yielding varieties of crops and demonstrating to them the method of cultivation have turned our food-deficit country of 1950s to a slightly food-surplus country of 1970s. This shows the effectiveness of extension workers in the dissemination

of information and varieties of information they possess. To villagers and other illiterate people they are proving to be a big source of information. There are various types of extension workers, for example, an agricultural extension worker is an intermediary who helps in the transfer of research results from the laboratory to the field. A public health extension worker disseminates information about methods of healthy living, family planning, etc.

Marketing Professionals: These professionals comprise of marketing executives, trade representatives, advertisers, hawkers, etc. A marketing executive is a person who is highly knowledgeable about the dynamism of the market. S/he knows the demand and supply position of various products and services, market trends, dynamic and sometimes volatile price situation of various commodities, customer psychology, formidable competitors, potential buyers, etc. Basing her/his knowledge on these s/he can visualise to a certain extent the future demand of a particular commodity or service, and further decide upon the marketing as well as advertising strategy in opportune time, and post the trade representatives at strategic positions.

A **trade representative** is a person who is employed by a firm for sales promotion and allied activities. Usually s/he is smart, speaks well, sometimes knows more than one language, has the capability of convincing people, and possesses basic knowledge about the products s/he is putting into market. Her/his activities, among others, include sales promotion, market survey, study of user reaction, identifying competitors in the field, locating prospective buyers, etc. This undoubtedly makes her/him a good source of information. Take for example, a medical representative. S/he covers a particular area and knows the names of all the doctors practising in the area, representatives of other companies operating there; the diseases people are suffering from, the medicines being prescribed by the doctors, medical facilities like hospitals, dispensaries, nursing homes, maternity centres, etc. existing there.

You might have noticed persons in buses, trains, weekly markets, and other busy places carrying some products and loudly announcing their benefits, qualities, prices, etc. These people are called **hawkers** and are usually employed by smaller forms for bringing their products to the notice of common people.

Recently **call centres** have emerged as a big disseminator of product and service information. Employees of the call centres contact the prospective customers through telephone and give them details about the products and services. It is like door to door dissemination of information, personalised, and hence, the effect in many cases is highly rewarding. Many foreign concerns, especially American, are taking the help of call centres in India to advertise their products and services in America itself to cut cost of advertising radically. Thus, people in call centres are becoming knowledgeable about American products and services.

By now, you must have realised that marketing executives, trade representatives, even hawkers are good sources of information for particular products. If you do not know how to advertise a product then the sources of information are advertising people.

Publishers: A publisher is usually a company that prints books, magazines, newspapers, etc. and make them available to the public at a cost. A regular publisher sends the book for review in newspapers, journals, etc. for review; advertises the book; sends representatives to libraries, displays the books in book fairs, etc. A publisher has the knowledge of the book market, the renowned authors whose books are sold in large numbers, the type of books which are sold more; and thus can decide which book is worthy of publishing and earning her/him profit.

Broadcasting Personnel: Newsreaders are the best examples of information disseminators. However, from the gathering of the news to its broadcast, apart from newsreaders, there are reporters, cameramen, editors, and others who give final shape to the news for broadcasting. Many of these people are also good sources of information on current affairs.

Consultants: A consultant is a professional who provides advice usually on payment basis. There are various categories of consultants such as legal consultants, engineering consultants, consulting physician, etc. In the case of litigation, we take the advice of a legal consultant. For setting up an air conditioning plant for an office building, a cinema hall, etc. we consult an engineer who is an expert in the matter. For our ailments, we consult a physician. In all cases we are to pay fees fixed by the consultants.

Teachers, doctors, lawyers and many others are also disseminators of information. We shall discuss some of them later.

5.3.7 Translators

Articles, news items, books, periodicals, patents, theses, etc. are appearing in numerous languages in the world such as English, Russian, German, French, Spanish, Chinese, Japanese, Hindi and Bengali. It is not possible for a person to learn all the languages. Hence, the need for translation or interpretation arises quite often. For getting a piece of writing translated we generally go to a translator. S/he informs us about the cost involved in translation and approximate time s/he will take for translating the piece. If s/he fails to undertake the job s/he may inform about another translator who can do the job. When oral translation is needed, we look for an interpreter. S/he also informs about her/his charges and availability. Some translators are highly knowledgeable about bilingual and multilingual dictionaries.

5.3.8 Information Condensers

Often information needs to be condensed as per the requirement of the user. Suppose, a minister has spoken about the information policy of a country for about an hour. A broadcasting agency is to report the speech of the minister in the news. Obviously, in 15-minute news, it is not possible to accommodate the one-hour-long speech of the minister. Hence, the editor has to put only the gist of the lecture in the news which can be read, say, in a minute or less. Similarly, a researcher may like to have the gist of an article published in a foreign language to ensure whether or not the article will be of any use to her/him. For these jobs we need persons who can condense the information. These persons are called abstractors. They know the art of abstracting, summarising, gist making, etc.

5.3.9 Information Retrievers

In this category we usually include those personnel who retrieve information on demand by searching reference books, databases, Internet, etc. We call these people reference librarians, database searchers, Internet searchers, etc. All these people are experts in their respective fields and good sources of information in the sense that they know where the information is available and can search out the information on demand.

5.3.10 Informetricians

Every moment information is being continuously generated in the world and is cumulating day by day. It is necessary, for various purposes, to know the rate of growth, decay, and many other properties of information. To study all these phenomena a new species of information professional has emerged called informetricians. They possess information about generation, growth, propagation, use and obsolescence of information, various laws governing these factors, the efficiency of information systems, services and products, and various types or relationship existing among subjects.

5.3.11 Information Preservers

Man since time immemorial has been trying to preserve information by various means. Even today man is discovering and inventing newer methods and media of preservation. These professionals are good sources of information about document preservation.

Self Check Exercise

Note: i) Write your answers in the space given below.

ii) Check your answers with the answers given at the end of this Unit.

- 2) Enumerate different species of information gatherers and describe the function of a reporter.

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- 3) Describe the function of a trade representative.

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- 4) Who are information disseminators? Explain how a librarian performs the function of an information disseminator.

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5.4 PERIPHERAL INFORMATION PROFESSIONALS

In this category we intend to include those who are usually not considered information professionals per se. But all of them are good sources of information. We are going to discuss some of them in the following sub-sections.

5.4.1 Lawyers

Form purchase of assets, to solving disputes, getting a society registered, and for various other purposes, we require legal help. Lawyers are the persons who provide us the necessary information. Like doctors, the lawyers also charge fees. There are various categories of lawyers. Some of them deal with civil cases like marriage registration, registration of journals, sales tax, income tax; legal procedure involved in the sale or purchase of properties, obtaining licenses for doing business, etc. Another category of lawyers deals with criminal cases such as cheating, theft, robbery, murder, etc. Depending on the crime the lawyer informs about the quantum of punishment, the possibility of winning a particular case, etc. There are patent attorneys who help the inventor in filing applications for patent, fighting cases relating to patents, etc. Lawyers collect information in the form of facts and compile petitions and prepare arguments.

5.4.2 Doctors

A person suffering from an ailment goes to a doctor for medicines whereby s/he is cured. The doctor first of all gathers information from the patient about the symptoms. Thereafter the doctor examines the patient. If the doctor can diagnose the disease, s/he informs the patient about the disease s/he is suffering from, prescribes medicines which the patient has to take or apply, tells her/him how many times and for how many days the medicines are to be taken, and also how the medicines are to be taken - by mouth or injection or they are simply to be applied on the affected area. For example, while prescribing antacid tablets like Digene for acidity, the doctor tells the patient to chew the tablet before swallowing. In case, the doctor cannot diagnose the disease, s/he asks the patient to get some pathological tests done. The results of the test help the doctor to diagnose the disease correctly. For health and diseases, doctors are the best source of information.

5.4.3 Teachers

Teachers possess information on the subject they teach, books and journals on the subject, institutions where the subject is taught within the country and abroad, other teachers on the subject, availability of scholarships, job opportunities, research facilities available within the country and abroad, etc. They also possess information about the students of their classes and many students whom they have taught earlier.

5.4.4 Experts

An expert is a person who possesses sound knowledge on a subject, technique, etc. On many occasions we need their help. For example, for appointing an information scientist in an organisation, we set up an interview board comprising of experts. They interview the candidates, judge their suitability for the post, and finally choose the best candidate depending on her/his knowledge, skill, qualification and experience. For classifying a book, many a times a classifier cannot decide the subject. In such a case, s/he usually takes the help of an expert who knows the subject.

5.4.5 Resource Persons

The connotation of the term 'resource person' varies depending on the context. Normally a resource person enriches a programme by virtue of her/his vast knowledge. S/he provides the main intellectual input to the course for which s/he is the resource person by delivering lectures, and enriching others lectures by her/his comments and suggestions.

5.4.6 Technological Gatekeepers

A technological gatekeeper is a well-informed person in a particular field. Usually, some scientists, technologists, and professionals in business, etc. have got a tendency (possibly inborn) to acquire information from various sources, to keep herself/himself abreast of the development in the field, and to disseminate the information to a person or group who may be interested in the information. There is no formal course to train a person as a technological gatekeeper. Almost automatically, they grow into a technological gatekeeper. According to Zagnoli [Internet 2] a technological gatekeeper should have:

- i) 'technical authority, a high standard of technical and scientific professionalism and a high level of verifiable performance (scientific publications, congress communications and internal relationships, etc.);
- ii) a formal role in the organization (often gatekeepers are coordinators of groups or project managers);
- iii) a proponent and constructive attitude to the general problems of the business; and
- iv) an open and interested attitude to innovation problems and to discussion with colleagues'.

5.4.7 Invisible College

In reality, an invisible college is not a college. Around 1645 A.D. a group of persons interested in natural philosophy and other parts of human learning started

meeting secretly at Gresham College and elsewhere in London under the name of the ‘invisible college’. In these meetings, they used to discuss about their research activities, results obtained, new areas that can be researched, etc. The practice continues till today, of course, not in secret but in open meetings like national and international conferences where scholars belonging to the same discipline get acquainted with each other, come to know who is doing what, and discuss during tea time, lunch and dinner their areas of research, problems they are facing, latest findings, etc. This acquaintance often turns into friendship which continues when they exchange their reprints, correspond with one another through letters, talk over the phone, etc. In this way, nowadays invisible colleges are formed. Hence, we can now define an invisible college as a loosely formed association of like minded people who come together to share their experiences and knowledge. It is more or less like an area specific knowledge society.

5.4.8 Common People

Children – A growing child starts picking up information while exploring her/his house, meeting relatives, playing with toys, etc. By the time a child is three, s/he can tell where a particular toy s/he has kept. In the pre-school a child learns about her/his friends, teachers, toys and equipment for playing available in the school, school building, environ of the school, etc. S/he gives this information to parents and others. In this way even in pre-schools s/he becomes a source of information.

In the school a child gathers a great deal of information and can provide information about the location of the school, school compound, school uniforms for boys and girls, classmates, teachers, books, school library, and the subjects s/he are being taught, various events happening in the school, etc.

In the school-going age a child starts reading newspapers, listening to radio, viewing TV, meeting relatives, family friends, and persons of the locality, exploring the locality, and thus gathers a world of information. A child by virtue of being curious often gathers more information than an adult. All these make a child a very good source of information.

In many cases, the information given by an innocent child is considered highly trustworthy. For example, the Rohini Court Special Judge Manoj Jain ‘relied almost solely on the eye-witness account of the six-year old [Aman Verma] to pass the verdict against his father’ [Pooran Verma] for murdering Sangeeta Verma [Aman’s mother] in a gruesome way in June 2008 (Bagga).

During user survey of school libraries, the children of the school provide all information required by the investigator.

Head of a family – During census operations and other surveys, usually the head of the family is consulted for various information. The information obtainable from her/him includes among others the name, age (date of birth, if available), sex, educational qualification, profession, marital status, health status, etc. of each family member. This apart, s/he can provide a lot of information such as, the house where the family lives, the amount of land and other property the family possesses, income the family generates, religion and caste of the family, religious ceremonies the family performs, holy places the family visits, relatives of the family and their respective locations, small scale industry the family is

engaged in, mode of communication as well as means of transport (cycles, scooters, etc.), of the family, costume of the family members, language the family speaks, sources of water and energy, doctors the family consults, hospitals the family visits, electronic gadgets the family uses (fridge, computer, radio, TV, VCR, etc.), crops the family cultivates, fruits the family grows, domestic animals including pets the family rears, food habit of the family, cultural programmes as well as sports and games the family takes part or views on TV, literary activities of the family (someone writing poems or composing songs), and also the history and genealogy of the family.

Village head – Possesses information about libraries or reading rooms (if any), non-government organisations working in the village; newspapers the villagers read, religions the villagers follow, religious and other festivals they organise, shrines the village has, castes of the village people, political affiliation of the villagers, panchayats, financial status of the villagers, availability of banks and loan providing institutions, household industries and small scale industries, development plans being executed, social welfare activities of the villagers, families falling below the poverty line, educational facilities available in the village and nearby areas, educational status of the village people, most educated person in the village; existence of post office, roads and transport facilities, folklores, the marriage customs, adults (both male and female) looking for marriage, languages and dialects the villagers speak, names of plants and animals in the local language/s, common diseases the villagers suffer from, availability of health facilities in the village and nearby areas, herbal drugs the villagers use, family planning methods being adopted by families, status of agricultural land, irrigation facilities, agricultural implements used, crops and vegetables grown throughout the year, fertilisers and pesticides used, forest and forest produce (if any), fruits and flowers grown, domestic animals reared, milk and milk products generated households, pisciculture, sericulture, beekeeping activities (if any), food and drink habit, garments they make and wear; status of housing (buildings, tin sheds, thatched houses, etc.), cultural activities they perform (music, dance, dramas, etc.), literature they generate (some villagers even those who are illiterate compose poems and songs, create short stories, jokes, etc. which form folk literature); archaeological site (if any), and also the history of the village.

The help of village head is often sought by government officials to prepare a list of families falling below the poverty lines, the family planning methods the villagers are adopting, polling booth for the village voters at the time of election, and various other information pertaining to the village. When house to house survey is not needed, the village head can provide the general information about the village.

Priest – A priest is an important person in a society. Usually s/he possesses the almanac (*panchang*) which provides plethora of information about the date and time of various religious festivals, ceremonies like marriage and *mundan*, auspicious time and inauspicious time of everyday, forecast for the year of each zodiac sign (*rashi*), list of items necessary for performing various *pujas* and other religious ceremonies, dates and times of solar and lunar eclipses, etc. In many cases s/he is a horoscope reader as well. By going through the horoscope of a person the priest tells about her/his future. Some priest maintain a good collection of almanacs using which s/he can tell the corresponding dates of two different eras, say Samvat and Gregorian era. Suppose your horoscope shows

your date of birth in Samvat era. If you are interested in knowing the corresponding date according to Gregorian calendar (the English calendar we use follows Gregorian calendar), a priest can help you.

Postman – Possesses information about every household and adult person of the area that falls under her/his jurisdiction. S/he also knows the names of all many adult persons of the locality. Sometimes police and strangers go to the postman to locate a particular person or household. Many a times police requires information from the postman as to the place or person wherefrom a particular person receives letters or money orders.

Police – Possess information about the law and order situation of the area which they serve and also information about every household. They are also aware about the criminals and criminal history of the area that falls under their jurisdiction. Biographers get a good deal of information from the police about celebrities who had spent sometime in jail while fighting for freedom or any other cause.

Matchmaker – In many countries of the world, arranged marriages are still prevalent where match makers are generally found. They possess information about brides and bridegrooms. Usually they keep in their records the photograph, information regarding height, age, complexion, qualification, employment, salary, family history, caste, religion, *gotra*, etc. of the bride and bridegroom. What they maintain can be termed as a small manually compiled or electronically generated database. They provide the information on payment basis. For obtaining information from a matchmaker one has to provide her/him the expected profile of a bride or bridegroom. If there is a match between the given profile and the profile within the ‘database’, the inquirer is informed.

Receptionist – Usually receptionists are found in commercial organisations like hotels, industrial establishments, banks, insurance companies, and airlines offices. They are also to be seen in many government and non-government offices. Usually they are smart, good looking, well-mannered, and fluent in conversation. Often they present the first information about an organisation. They possess substantial information about the organisation, its employees, the names and phone numbers of the head of the organisation, senior executives, junior executives, and others, history, objectives, functions, and achievements of the organisation, testing and other facilities (if any) the organisation has, products of the organisation (if any), publications of the organisation (if any), etc.

Self Check Exercise

Note: i) Write your answers in the space given below.

ii) Check your answers with the answer given at the end of this Unit.

5) Explain how a teacher performs the function of a disseminator of information.

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- 6) Who are technological gatekeepers? Briefly explain.

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5.5 BIOGRAPHY OF A CELEBRITY

Information is usually obtained from such human sources as parents (if alive), brother/s, sister/s, son/s, daughter/s, relatives, friends, co-workers, personal secretaries, and aides. For a freedom fighter's biography, jailors at times become a potential source of information. This apart, usual help is taken from librarians, information scientists, etc.

5.6 EVENTS

Everyday countless events are taking place in the world such as meetings, conferences, festivals, fairs, exhibitions, games, births, deaths, and so on. In addition, there are events which had happened in the past, and there are many others that will take place in future. To gather information on many of these events human sources in many cases will be the best source and in some cases the only source.

5.6.1 Accidents and Disasters

Various types of accidents and disasters take place everyday on the earth. Information regarding these is usually gathered from eyewitnesses or the survivors. Some examples are given below:

Swine flu – In April 2009, people in Mexico were afflicted with a new disease called swine flu. In medical history this was the first time that humans became the victim of this disease. The deadly disease, caused by a virus called H1N1, spread across the world rapidly creating panic amongst people.

To generate a full-length **report** on the disease, the reporters of *Reader's Digest* interviewed a survivor (Julie Cesar Ruiz Ocampo), a nurse, paramedic Armando Gonzalez, and Ricardo Quizano, the scientist who isolated the virus.

Titanic Disaster – The British luxury passenger liner called *Titanic* sank on 15 April 1912 in its maiden voyage from Southampton, England to New York, USA after hitting an iceberg. The liner was carrying 2200 people, of which more than 1500 perished. It is the survivors who provided the entire information about the disaster.

5.7 SURVEY

Poll Prediction – Every time an election is held in India, various news channels predict the poll results in advance. For doing this the media people are to interview thousands of voters throughout the length and breadth of the country.

Opinion Survey – Many newspapers conduct an opinion survey everyday. The newspaper put a question which the readers answer. From the answer it becomes clear how the people are considering the issue.

Survey for a Research Work – Many researchers including LIS professionals follow survey method for their research work. Often, they prepare a questionnaire and distribute the same to the persons from whom information is being sought. Sometimes the research workers are to interview the persons also to elicit information. In this case also information is elicited from human sources only.

Self Check Exercise

Note: i) Write your answer in the space given below.

ii) Check your answer with the answer given at the end of this Unit.

7) For writing a biographical sketch of a person, whom would you consult for information?

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5.8 SUMMARY

In this Unit first of all an attempt has been made to differentiate between the concepts ‘human source’ and ‘human resource’. All sensible human beings are sources of information. Some are directly involved with information such as information generators, information gatherers, compilers, information processors, information recorders, information disseminators and many others. They have been termed as ‘core information professionals’. Apart from these there are others such as lawyers, doctors, teachers, experts and resource persons in various fields, technological gatekeepers, invisible college members, and finally commoners who also act as good sources of information. These people have been termed as ‘peripheral information professionals’. All these sources have been described to present before you the entire panorama of human sources. The categories of information sources that are to be consulted while writing a biography of a celebrity, preparing a report of an event, or conducting a survey have also been highlighted.

5.9 ANSWERS TO SELF CHECK EXERCISES

1) The term ‘human source’ belongs to library and information science, and ‘human resource’ to economics and management. Human sources mean human beings as sources of information and human resources mean employees of an organisation. The employees of a library or any other

organisation are human resources and all sensible human beings in the world are human sources of information.

- 2) Reporters, correspondents, detectives, spies, police, compilers, enumerators, etc. are information gatherers by profession.

A reporter collects all possible information relating to an event depending on its importance and reports it to the press along with photographs and other associated materials if that is possible. One moral responsibility that lies with the reporter is that the information s/he passes on to the press for wider dissemination should be authentic to the best of her/his knowledge. To establish the authenticity of the report, s/he has to check and crosscheck the information from various vital sources. Suppose, due to police firing some persons have been injured. When the reporter reaches the spot, s/he is likely to get different figures from different persons as to the number of persons injured and different views as to the cause of firing. To establish the actual number of persons injured, s/he may have to go to the nearby doctors and hospital(s) where the persons have received first aid or have been admitted for treatment. S/he may also visit the concerned police station to ascertain the number of persons injured and the cause of firing. S/he may also interview the injured people themselves, the people present at the scene, local political leaders, and other reliable sources to build up her/his entire report.

- 3) A trade representative is employed by a firm for sales promotion and allied activities. Usually s/he is smart, speaks well, sometimes knows more than one language, has the capability of convincing people, and possesses basic knowledge about the products s/he is putting into market. Her/his activities, among others, include sales promotion, market survey, study of user reaction, identifying competitors in the field, locating prospective buyers, etc. This undoubtedly makes her/him a good source of information. Take, for example, a medical representative. Usually s/he possesses the degree of B. Pharm. and is knowledgeable about all medicines usually used for treatment. S/he covers a particular area and knows the names of all the doctors practising in the area, representatives of other companies operating there, the diseases people are suffering from, the medicines being prescribed by the doctors, medical facilities like hospitals, dispensaries, nursing homes, maternity centres, etc. existing there.
- 4) The professionals belonging to this category are: library professionals, documentalists, information officers, extension workers, publishers, trade representatives, receptionists, consultants, marketing officers, broadcasting professionals, press professionals, advertisers, teachers, doctors, lawyers, and hawkers.

Librarians disseminate information in various ways. All librarians compile a catalogue of books and other documents available in the library. Using the catalogue they tell inquirers what books by an author are available in the library, books available on a particular subject or pertaining to a series, whether a book with a particular title is available in the library, etc. Many librarians bring out accession list of the library concerned from time to time. This list informs users about the books added to the library during a particular time. A reference librarian answers many queries of the users using the library

collection. Often s/he also informs where a particular book or periodical may be available which is not there in the library collection.

- 5) A teacher is an expert on the subject s/he teaches. The same information s/he disseminates to her/his students in the class. S/he also knows about books and journals on her/his subject, institutions where her/his subject is taught within the country and abroad, other teachers on her/his subject, availability of scholarships, job opportunities, research facilities available within the country and abroad, etc. On inquiry, s/he disseminates these information.
- 6) A technological gatekeeper is a well-informed person in a particular field. Usually, some scientists, technologists, and professionals in business, etc. have got a tendency (possibly inborn) to acquire information from various sources, to keep themselves abreast of the development in their field, and to disseminate the information to a person or group who may be interested in the information. There is no formal course to train a person as a technological gatekeeper. Almost automatically, they grow into a technological gatekeeper.
- 7) Information is usually gathered from such human sources as parents (if alive), spouse, brother/s, sister/s, son/s, daughter/s, relatives, friends, co-workers, personal secretaries, and aides. For a freedom fighter's biography, jailors at times become a potential source of information. This apart, usual help is taken from librarians, information scientists, etc.

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UNIT 6 INSTITUTIONS AS SOURCES OF INFORMATION

Structure

- 6.0 Objectives
- 6.1 Introduction
- 6.2 Government Ministries and Departments
- 6.3 International Agencies
- 6.4 R&D Organisations
- 6.5 Academic Institutions
- 6.6 Learned Societies
- 6.7 Publishing Houses
- 6.8 Press
- 6.9 Broadcasting Stations
- 6.10 Museums
- 6.11 Archives
- 6.12 Non-Governmental Organisations
- 6.13 Summary
- 6.14 Answers to Self Check Exercises
- 6.15 Keywords
- 6.16 References and Further Reading

6.0 OBJECTIVES

After reading this Unit, you will be able to:

- describe the different types of premier institutions in different sectors;
- explain the products, services, publications, activities, facilities, achievements, programmes, important persons, address, history, etc. of different types of institutions; and
- highlight the importance of institutions as an important source of information.

6.1 INTRODUCTION

Among the many non-documentary sources of information, institutions are a major source of information. An institution is a large important organisation that has a purpose. A university for example is an educational institution and a bank is a financial institution. In addition to the people who manage and run the institution, other components such as its various resources including files, documents and the organisational website cumulatively make institution a rich source of information. Many large libraries are information institutions whose primary objective is to acquire, organise and fulfil information needs of users. Apart from libraries and information centres, there are numerous other organisations which have varied objectives. Such organisations may be research

institutes, commercial organisations, international bodies involved in developmental work, government departments, etc. In this Unit we shall discuss these institutions that act as sources of information.

6.2 GOVERNMENT MINISTRIES AND DEPARTMENTS

The various ministries of the government are authentic sources of primary data and information. The executive, legislature, judiciary, states, union territories and districts of the Indian government have a structured mechanism for carrying out its many activities and disseminating much needed information through its various institutions and organisations. The list of ministries is given below in Table 6.1.

Table 6.1: List of Ministries of Govt. of India

• Ministry of Agriculture • Ministry of Chemicals and Fertilizers • Ministry of Civil Aviation • Ministry of Coal • Ministry of Commerce and Industry • Ministry of Communications and Information Technology • Ministry of Consumer Affairs, Food and Public Distribution • Ministry of Corporate Affairs • Ministry of Culture • Ministry of Defence • Ministry of Development of North Eastern Region • Ministry of Earth Sciences • Ministry of Environment and Forests • Ministry of External Affairs • Ministry of Finance • Ministry of Food Processing Industries • Ministry of Health and Family Welfare • Ministry of Heavy Industries and Public Enterprises • Ministry of Home Affairs • Ministry of Housing and Urban Poverty Alleviation • Ministry of Human Resource Development • Ministry of Information and Broadcasting • Ministry of Labour and Employment • Ministry of Law and Justice	• Ministry of Micro, Small and Medium Enterprises • Ministry of Mines • Ministry of Minority Affairs • Ministry of New and Renewable Energy • Ministry of Overseas Indian Affairs • Ministry of Panchayati Raj • Ministry of Parliamentary Affairs • Ministry of Personnel, Public Grievances and Pensions • Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas • Ministry of Planning • Ministry of Power • Ministry of Railways • Ministry of Road Transport and Highways • Ministry of Rural Development • Ministry of Science and Technology • Ministry of Shipping • Ministry of Social Justice and Empowerment • Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation • Ministry of Steel • Ministry of Textiles • Ministry of Tourism • Ministry of Tribal Affairs • Ministry of Urban Development • Ministry of Water Resources • Ministry of Women and Child Development • Ministry of Youth Affairs and Sports
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The policies announced by the government from time to time are available to the information seeker through the various government ministries and departments. Welfare-oriented activities of many ministries that require outreach or wide provisioning of information have offices at district and even the rural levels. Let us take the example of one of the ministries, the Ministry of Human Resource Development. The Ministry has two departments, the Department of School Education and Literacy and Department of Higher Education. The speeches and announcements of the ministers and other important officials of the Ministry are important sources of information. So are the numerous documents and files in the Ministry. The files are a valuable source when the Ministry has to formulate plans and policies. The Ministry also gives information to students who travel abroad for higher studies. These and other information are disseminated through its various departments and bureaus. The website of the Ministry is also a very rich source of information.

As another specific example, the Ministry of Agriculture has an Agricultural Planning and Information Bank (APIB) for the East Khasi Hills District of Meghalaya that is a single window access to knowledge related to agriculture and allied sectors useful for the farmers, extension personnel and planners.

The government ministries and departments have their organisational presence in almost all sectors, be it banking, financial, insurance, cooperatives, cultural, educational, health, public sector, scientific research, sports, tourism, hospitality, etc. Ministry of Information and Broadcasting, Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation, Ministry of Human Resource Development, Ministry of Science and Technology and Ministry of Communications and Information Technology are some of the notable ministries that have highly organised mechanisms for information provisioning.

In the recent years, the Right to Information Act 2005 (RTI) that mandates timely response to citizen requests for government information has broken new grounds in providing information to the citizens. It is “an Act to provide for setting out the practical regime of right to information for citizens to secure access to information under the control of public authorities, in order to promote transparency and accountability in the working of every public authority, the constitution of a Central Information Commission and State Information Commissions and for matters connected therewith or incidental thereto.”

6.3 INTERNATIONAL AGENCIES

There are many international agencies that are involved in developmental programmes and have presence across the globe, especially in the developing countries.

The United Nations (UN) with its several programmes, research and training institutes, other UN entities such as the United Nations University and many subsidiary bodies and commissions as given in Table 6.2 is a rich source of information in numerous areas. Particularly, the United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organisation (UNESCO), founded in 1945 is a specialised agency of United Nations that promotes international cooperation among its 193 Member States and six Associate Members in the fields of education, science, culture and communication. UNESCO serves as a clearing house – for the dissemination and sharing of information and knowledge- while helping Member States to build their human and institutional capacities in diverse fields.

Table 6.2: UNO and its Main Bodies, Research and Training Institutes, Programmes and Funds and Specialised Agencies

Institutions as Sources of Information

Main Bodies	Programmes and Funds
• General Assembly • Security Council • Economic and Social Council • Trusteeship Council • International Court of Justice • Secretariat • Repertory of Practice of United Nations Organs	• International Trade Centre (ITC) • Office of the United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees (UNHCR) • United Nations Children's Fund (UNICEF) • United Nations Conference on Trade and Development (UNCTAD) • United Nations Development Programme (UNDP) • United Nations Capital Development Fund (UNCDF) • United Nations Volunteers (UNV) • United Nations Drug Control Programme (UNDCP) • United Nations Environment Programme (UNEP) • United Nations Human Settlements Programme (UN-HABITAT) • United Nations Population Fund (UNFPA) • United Nations Relief and Works Agency for Palestine Refugees in the Near East (UNRWA) • United Nations World Food Programme (WFP)
Research and Training Institutes • United Nations Institute for Disarmament Research (UNIDIR) • United Nations Institute for Training and Research (UNITAR) • United Nations Interregional Crime and Justice Research Institute (UNICRI) • United Nations Research Institute for Social Development (UNRISD)	Specialised Agencies • Food and Agriculture Organization of the United Nations (FAO) • International Civil Aviation Organization (ICAO) • International Fund for Agricultural Development (IFAD) • International Labour Organization (ILO) • International Maritime Organization (IMO) • International Monetary Fund (IMF) • International Telecommunication Union (ITU) • United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization (UNESCO) • United Nations Industrial Development Organization (UNIDO) • Universal Postal Union (UPU) • World Bank Group ○ International Bank for Reconstruction and Development (IBRD) ○ International Centre for Settlement of Investment Disputes (ICSID) ○ International Development Association (IDA) ○ International Finance Corporation (IFC) ○ Multilateral Investment Guarantee Agency (MIGA) • World Health Organization (WHO) • World Intellectual Property Organization (WIPO) • World Meteorological Organization (WMO) • World Tourism Organization (UNWTO)

The World Health Organization (WHO) is another institution within the United Nations system which is the directing and coordinating authority on health. It is responsible for providing leadership on global health matters, shaping the health research agenda, setting norms and standards, articulating evidence-based policy options, providing technical support to countries and monitoring and assessing health trends. The WHO is a valuable source on global health information, data and statistics. The organisation brings out several publications and reports, many of which are available free of cost. Some key publications of WHO include *The World Health Report*, *World Health Statistics*, *International Travel and Health*, *International Health Regulations*, *The International Classification of Diseases* and *International Pharmacopoeia*.

The Food and Agriculture Organization (FAO) of the United Nations leads international efforts to defeat hunger. Serving both developed and developing countries, FAO acts as a neutral forum where all nations meet as equals to negotiate agreements and debate policy. Importantly, FAO is also a source of knowledge and information. FAO helps developing countries and countries in transition, modernise and improve agriculture, forestry and fisheries practices and ensure good nutrition for all. Publications are central to FAO's work as a knowledge organisation. More than 300 titles per year are published by FAO in multiple languages, on topics such as hunger and food security, commodity markets, climate change, nutrition, fisheries, forests, rural livelihoods, etc. FAO's most important publications present comprehensive and objective information and analysis on the current global state of food and agriculture, fisheries and aquaculture, forests, agricultural commodity markets and hunger. These titles are issued regularly to inform public, debate and policy making at national and international levels. Some of these publications are: *The State of Food and Agriculture (SOFA)*, *The State of World Fisheries and Aquaculture (SOFIA)*, *State of the World's Forests (SOFO)*, *The State of Food Insecurity in the World (SOFI)* and *The State of Agricultural Commodity Markets (SOCO)*.

Asian Development Bank (ADB) – a multilateral finance institution that promotes economic and social progress in the Asia-Pacific region, The International Development Research Centre (IDRC) – a public corporation created by the Canadian government to help communities in the developing world find solutions to social, economic, and environmental problems they face, South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation (SAARC) – an organisation of South Asian nations dedicated to economic, technological, social, and cultural development emphasising collective self-reliance and Association of South Eastern Asian Nations (ASEAN) – a geo-political and economic organisation of 10 countries located in Southeast Asia are some other agencies that are important sources of information.

Self Check Exercise

Note: i) Write your answer in the space given below.

ii) Check your answer with the answers given at the end of this Unit.

- 1) Enumerate some of the important international agencies that are sources of information. Highlight the role of UNESCO as a vital source of information.

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There are several research and development (R&D) organisations in the country under the aegis of many government departments such as the Department of Science and Technology (DST), Department of Biotechnology (DBT), Council of Scientific and Industrial Research (CSIR), Indian Council of Medical Research (ICMR), Indian Council of Agricultural Research (ICAR), and Defence Research and Development Organisation (DRDO). There are also many private R&D organisations. Many of the laboratories of these umbrella organisations are not only well known but have been recognised as important sources of information in specific areas. In the case of CSIR, many of the laboratories' libraries and information centres function as national information centres. The erstwhile National Information System for Science and Technology (NISSAT) had facilitated formation of 14 national centres dealing with specialised sectors. These information centres were built around existing information resources and facilities. The centres of erstwhile NISSAT are given in Table 6.3.

Table 6.3: National Information Centres

National Information Centre		Institution/Library	CSIR/vs. Non-CSIR
1.	NICLAI – National Information Centre on Leather and Allied Industries	Central Leather Research Institute	CSIR
2.	NICFOS – National Information Centre on Food Science	Central Food Technological Research Institute	CSIR
3.	NICMAP – National Information Centre for Machine Tools and Allied Products	Central Manufacturing Technology Institute	Non-CSIR
4.	NICRYS – National Information Centre for Crystallography	University of Madras	Non-CSIR
5.	NICDAP – National Information Centre for Drugs and Pharmaceuticals	Central Drug Research Institute	CSIR
6.	NICTAS – National Information Centre for Textiles and Allied Subjects	Ahmedabad Textile Industry's Research Association	Non-CSIR
7.	NICHEM – National Information Centre for Chemicals and Allied Industries	National Chemical Laboratory	CSIR
8.	NICAC – National Information Centre for Advanced Ceramics	Central Glass and Ceramics Research Institute	CSIR
9.	NCB – National Centre for Bibliometrics	Indian National Scientific Documentation Centre	CSIR
10.	NICDROM – National Information Centre for CD-ROMs	National Aeronautical Laboratory	CSIR
11.	NICMAN – National Information Centre on Management Science	Indian Institute of Management, Ahmedabad	Non-CSIR
12.	NICMAT – National Information Centre on Tea Manufacturing and Marketing	Tea Board	Non-CSIR
13.	NICMAS – National Information Centre for Marine and Aquatic Sciences	National Institute of Oceanography	CSIR
14.	NCPC – National Centre for Publications on CD-ROM	Foundation for Innovation of Technology Transfer	Non-CSIR

From Table 6.3 it can be seen that out of the 14 national information centres involved in NISSAT, eight were set up with the CSIR libraries. With the discontinuance of the NISSAT programme, some of the centres such as NCB, NICRYS, NCPC, NICMAT, NICAC don't seem to be functional anymore as envisaged. However, some others such as NICMAS, NICLAI, NICFOS, NICDAP and NICTAS still continue as national information centres in specific areas.

A typical R&D organisation is an information consumer as well as information generator. This characteristic of an R&D organisation makes it an important source of information on two accounts. As the R&D institutes are consumers of information, the institutes usually have rich libraries and information centres that is a valuable source of information in a given field. By virtue of the research and development activities that are being carried out, the R&D organisations are important sources of primary information. Of course, the findings of research activities that are carried out usually get reported in documentary sources such as conference proceedings, journals or patents, nevertheless, for an information seeker the organisation can provide authentic and current information on an area of research pursued by the scientists therein.

It should also be remembered that most R&D institutions hold conferences and seminars which are important platforms for knowledge sharing, discussions and networking among the scientists and researchers. Many research institutions also have the concept of 'open day' or 'open house' wherein the general public are invited to exhibitions and demonstration of the R&D institutes' various facilities and technologies which in turn itself is an information gathering and enriching experience.

6.5 ACADEMIC INSTITUTIONS

Schools, universities, colleges and other specialised academic institutions not only impart knowledge but also play an important role in moulding the lives of youngsters for their future careers and also being a part of a good citizenry. Academic institutions, particularly the higher education institutions such as universities are sources of various kinds of information.

As academic institutions would be conducting several courses, information on the courses and programmes offered is the one of the many different kind of information that is provided. Centres or departments in the academic institutions that deal with placements of students, public relations, industry partnership, commercialisation of technologies and alumni are some of the areas on which the academic institution disseminates information. The academic institutions also have well-stocked libraries that are an important source of information in itself. Many academic institutions even have museums that complement the institutions in providing information.

The Nalanda University in India was the oldest university system of education in the world. India now has over 400 universities including central, state, deemed and private universities. Some of the prominent universities in India include the University of Delhi, Jawaharlal Nehru University, Banaras Hindu University, University of Madras, University of Mumbai, etc.

6.6 LEARNED SOCIETIES

A learned society is an organisation that exists to promote an academic discipline or group of disciplines. Most learned societies are non-profit organisations. Their activities typically include holding regular conferences for the presentation and discussion of new research results and publishing or sponsoring academic journals in their discipline. Some also act as professional bodies, regulating the activities of their members in the public interest or the collective interest of the membership of the society. Many times, the formation of a society is an important step in the emergence of a new discipline or sub-discipline.

Historically, the learned societies have played a very important role in furthering research and most vitally, serving as a body for information dissemination and knowledge sharing. One of the finest examples of a renowned learned society is the Royal Society of London. The Royal Society is the world's oldest scientific academy in continuous existence, and has been at the forefront of enquiry and discovery since its foundation in 1660. Throughout its history, the Society has promoted excellence in science through its Fellowship and Foreign Membership, which has included Isaac Newton, Charles Darwin, Ernest Rutherford, Albert Einstein, Dorothy Hodgkin, Francis Crick, James Watson, and Stephen Hawking. The credit for the publication of one of the earliest journals in the year 1665, the *Philosophical Transactions* goes to the Royal Society.

Every country has learned societies and associations in many academic disciplines. American Association for the Advancement of Science (AAAS), and American Chemical Society (ACS) are also among renowned learned societies.

India also has a number of learned societies in different disciplines. The Asiatic Society, The Geological Society of India, and The Indian Physical Society are some of the learned societies. The Asiatic Society was founded in the year 1784 by Sir William Jones (1746-1794) who began his work with a dream that visualised a Centre for Asian Studies including almost everything concerning man and nature within the geographical limits of the continent. The library of The Asiatic Society has about 1,49,000 volumes, particularly rich in works on Indology and Asiatic Lore, and in standard philological and scientific serials. The printed books in this department range in date from the latter half of the 15th century A.D. and one of its special features consists in the many items of rare works, otherwise unavailable, or scarcely available, including books printed in India in the late 18th and early 19th centuries. The total number of manuscripts in 26 scripts and languages are 47,000 (approx). The total numbers of journals are about 80,000. The Museum of the Asiatic Society has a large collection of paintings, manuscripts, sculptures, bronzes, coins, and inscriptions.

Given the nature, scope, objectives and functions of some of the learned societies, it can be well understood that they are precious sources of historical as well as recent information in a given discipline.

Self Check Exercise

Note: i) Write your answer in the space given below.

ii) Check your answer with the answers given at the end of this Unit.

2) ‘Learned societies are an indispensable source of information.’ Explain.

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6.7 PUBLISHING HOUSES

Publishing houses are in the information business by way of publishing a variety of documentary sources, predominantly books and of course others such as maps, atlases and other documents. Publishing by itself is a process of production and dissemination of literature or information. Traditionally, publishing referred to printed materials. However, with the advent of ICT applications, especially the Internet, publishing is being redefined.

Publishing can be done by an individual, such as an author himself or herself. However, there are large publishing houses that publish a variety of materials including books and periodicals. By virtue of being in the information business, the publishing houses are a vital source of information.

Types of publishing include the newspaper, periodical, book, directory and academic publishing. Academic publishing distributes academic research and scholarship. Most academic works are published in the form of journal articles, books or theses. The part of academic written output that is not formally published but merely printed or posted is often called the “grey literature”. Most scientific and scholarly journals, and many academic and scholarly books, though not all, are based on some form of peer review or editorial refereeing to qualify texts for publication. Peer review quality and selectivity standards vary greatly from journal to journal, publisher to publisher, and field to field.

Elsevier and Springer are among the major publishers that bring out a number of scientific periodicals and books. Most of the major publishers are now making available their resources online which can be accessed by users through different payment modes.

6.8 PRESS

Like the publishing house, the press or the print news media are also institutions in the information business, although with the difference being that the press and print news media focuses on current news and events. Newspapers are a

valuable documentary source of current information. In addition to the general newspapers, sports, business, trade, science and other such narrow areas also have newspapers and news magazines that aim to disseminate information to the users.

Press also play an important role in archiving information. Such archived information is of great value to the information seekers including students, researchers, investigators, film makers, authors, etc.

6.9 BROADCASTING STATIONS

Broadcasting stations include the radio and television stations that broadcast programmes for entertainment and news. In the present times, the television, in particular, has become an integral of part of one's life as a source of entertainment and general awareness. From modest beginnings, radio and television stations in India have proliferated so much that India is one of the countries that have the highest number of news channels. Today, many broadcasting stations, including several private ones, air programmes, many of which have enormous information value.

Other than entertainment, the broadcasting stations are also being used to support education through the various radio and television programmes. For example, IGNOU's Gyan Vani and Gyan Darshan are educational broadcasting stations on radio and television respectively. The regional radio programmes of India, promotes the tradition and culture of the respective state through discussions with the experts. These Indian radio programmes often invite social activists and experts to their studios to discuss various issues, and enlighten the audience of the same.

6.10 MUSEUMS

A museum is a building or institution which houses a collection of artifacts. Museums collect and care for objects of scientific, artistic, or historical importance and make them available for public viewing through exhibits that may be permanent or temporary. Most large museums are located in major cities throughout the world and more local ones exist in smaller cities, towns and even the countryside. Early museums began as the private collections of wealthy individuals, families or institutions of art and rare or curious natural objects and artifacts.

There are museums all over the world. The museums of ancient times, such as the Museum of Alexandria, would be equivalent to a modern graduate institute. The modern meaning of the word can be traced to the Museum of Pergamon in Anatolia, which displayed artwork.

Unlike the press and broadcasting houses that help to serve current information, the museums are organisations that are a major source of ancient and historical information. There are different kinds of museums on different areas such as science museum and rail museum. The museums store and display artefacts, relics and other ancient material and also give information regarding the same for the benefit of the information seekers.

There are a number of museums in India. The National Museum, New Delhi is the prime museum in the country. The blue-print for establishing the National Museum in Delhi had been prepared by the Gwyer Committee set up by the Government of India in 1946. When an Exhibition of Indian Art consisting of selected artefacts from various museums of India, sponsored by the Royal Academy (London) with the cooperation of the Government of India and Britain, was on display in the galleries of Burlington House, London during 1947-48, it was decided to display the same collection under a single roof in Delhi before the return of exhibits to their respective museums. Accordingly, the exhibition was held in the state rooms of the Rashtrapati Bhawan, New Delhi in 1949, and it turned out to be a great success. In turn, the event proved responsible for the creation of the National Museum.

On 15th August, 1949, the National Museum was formally inaugurated by the Governor-General of India, Shri R.C. Rajagopalachari, and it was announced that till a permanent building for housing the National Museum was constructed, the Museum would continue to function in the Rashtrapati Bhawan. The Government also felt to retain the exhibits on show to form the holdings of the National Museum and the plan was sent to all the participants of London exhibition. The National Museum received several gifts but artifacts were collected mainly through its Art Purchase Committee. In the meanwhile, the foundation of the present building was laid by Pt. J.L. Nehru, Prime Minister of India, on 12th May, 1955 and the new building where works of art were displayed on scientific lines, was handed over to Museum authorities in June, 1960. The Museum was formally thrown open to the public on December 18, 1960. And it is now within the administrative control of and fully financed by the Department of Culture, Ministry of Human Resource Development, Government of India.

The Museum has in its possession approximately 2,00,000 works of exquisite art of diverse nature, both Indian and foreign, and its holdings cover a time span of more than five thousand years of India's cultural heritage. The chronological display of selected art objects in the various galleries, screening of educational films related to art and culture, guided tours, gallery talks by the experts, special lectures and training programmes, facilities for photography and access to the reserve collection and library for the study, and advice on identification of art objects are all information providing activities of the Museum.

The National Museum conducts training courses on care of paintings and illustrated manuscripts and organises exhibitions from time to time. Since its inception, the National Museum has been bringing out various publications for the people from all walks of life. There are books for children, for common visitors and for the scholars interested in the study of art, architecture, painting, sculptures, history, religion, culture, etc. Besides bringing out art publications on Indian art and culture, the National Museum also brings out a quarterly newsletter, a research journal, research publications, guide books, gallery sheets, brochures on exhibitions and galleries, catalogues, monographs, activity books, picture postcard, reproductions and other finding aids required by the scholars and general public.

Note: i) Write your answer in the space given below.

ii) Check your answer with the answers given at the end of this Unit.

3) What are the activities of a museum that make it an information provider?

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6.11 ARCHIVES

Archives, like museums are storehouses of documents that have great historical value. An archive is a collection of historical records. Archives consist of records which have been selected for permanent or long-term preservation on grounds of their enduring cultural, historical or evidentiary value. Archival records are normally unpublished and almost always unique, unlike books or magazines for which many identical copies exist. Archives are quite distinct from libraries with regard to their functions and organisation, although archival collections can often be found within library buildings as well.

The National Archives of India is the repository of the non-current records of the Government of India and is holding them in trust for the use of administrators and scholars. It is an Attached Office of the Department of Culture under the Ministry of Tourism and Culture. It was set up in March 1891 in Calcutta (Kolkata) as the Imperial Record Department and subsequent to the transfer of the National Capital from Calcutta to New Delhi in 1911. The records were made available for bonafide research in 1939 and by 1947 all pre 1902 records were available for consultation. After independence, the Imperial Records Department was rechristened as National Archives of India. In 1947, the Departmental Journal *The Indian Archives* came into existence which contains research papers on source material of modern Indian history, conservation of documents, records-management, reprographics, archival awareness and all other allied aspects of functional archives.

National Archives of India is the nodal agency of Government of India for the implementation of the Public Records Act, 1993 and the Public Records Rules, 1997 made under the Act. The Act regulates the management, administration and preservation of all public records of the Central Government and the Union Territory administrations.

The National Archives of India is responsible for not only keeping in safe custody, the records of the various ministries/ departments of the Government of India, but is also engaged in devising suitable mechanism to streamline the management of their records in a systematic manner so that they can be used by administrators and scholars at ease. It also advises the state governments, custodial institutions, etc. in proper upkeep and management of their records. Preservation, reprographic services, reference service and training programmes on archives and records management are provided by the National Archives of India.

The National Film Archive of India is yet another example of an archive that aims to safeguard the heritage of Indian cinema for posterity and act as a centre for dissemination of a healthy film culture in the country. Promotion of film scholarship and research on various aspects of cinema also form part of its Charter. Familiarising foreign audiences with Indian Cinema and to make it more visible across the globe is another declared objective of the Archive. Many newspaper houses and other organisations also set up archives.

6.12 NON-GOVERNMENTAL ORGANISATIONS

According to Peter Willetts, “Non-governmental organization is defined as an independent voluntary association of people acting together on a continuous basis, for some common purpose, other than achieving government office, making money or illegal activities”. Further, it is legally constituted and operates independently from any government thus does not have government status. Some NGOs are funded totally or partially by governments, and such NGOs maintain their non-governmental status by excluding government representatives from membership in the organisation. Elaborating on Willetts definition, it must be remembered that most NGOs pursue some wider social aim that has political aspects, but that are not overtly political organisations such as political parties. Sometimes NGOs are also known as “civil society organisations”, “non-profit organisations” or referred to by other names.

In India, even before independence, there were a number of civil society organisations. On the basis of a civil society brief prepared by the Asian Development Bank (ADB) the Government of India established the Central Social Welfare Board in 1953 to promote social welfare activities and support people’s participation programmes through NGOs. Following this, there has been a body of professional NGOs in India. International NGOs entered India in significant numbers to provide drought relief during two consecutive agricultural seasons, 1965–1966 and 1966–1967. Many of them established permanent local operations thereafter. Moreover, foreign funds began flowing to domestic NGOs in India, changing the character of civil society once more.

During the 1970s, India witnessed a rapid increase in and diversification of the NGO sector as a response to the national political scenario and increasing concern about poverty and marginalisation. Both welfare and empowerment oriented organisations emerged during this period, and the issues of development, civil liberties, education, environment, health, and livelihood all became the focus of attention. With community participation as a defined component in a number of social sector projects during the 1970s and 1980s, NGOs began to be formally recognised as development partners of the state. Their work was increasingly characterised by grassroots interventions, advocacy at various levels, and mobilisation of the marginalised to protect their rights.

According to the ADB brief, as of 2009 there were 1.5 million NGOs work in India (i.e., non-profit, voluntary citizens’ groups organised on a local, national, or international level). This includes temples, churches, mosques, *gurudwaras* (Sikh place of worship), sports associations, hospitals, educational institutions, and *ganeshotsav mandals* (temporary structures set up to house Ganesh festival celebrations). Most NGOs in India are small and dependent on volunteers. The ADB brief also reports that according to a survey conducted by Society for

Participatory Research in Asia (PRIA), 73.4% of NGOs have one or no paid staff, although across the country, more than 19 million persons work as volunteers or paid staff at an NGO. The PRIA survey also revealed that 26.5% of NGOs are engaged in religious activities, while 21.3% work in the area of community and/or social service. Reportedly, about one in five NGOs works in education, while 17.9% are active in the fields of sports and culture. Only 6.6% work in the health sector.

To further, its activities and functions, all NGOs irrespective of their areas of work create information materials which range from simple brochures to elaborate reports. With many NGOs receiving grants from funding agencies for executing project, the NGOs have to prepare project reports which are a valuable source of primary information. All NGOs bring out one or the other information product, including directories, yearbooks, proceedings, etc.

NGO types by level of operation include:

- a) community-based organisations that arise out of people's own initiatives, e.g. sports clubs, women's organisations;
- b) religious or educational organisations;
- c) national or international NGOs, or bilateral or international agencies, and others independent of outside help;
- d) citywide organisations such as the Rotary or Lion's Club;
- e) national NGOs include organisations such as the Red Cross, YMCAs/ YWCAs; and
- f) professional organisations such as The Energy Resources Institute (TERI), Pratham.

There are many NGOs working towards the welfare and rights of children. *Child in Need Institute (CINI)*, India is a leading NGO founded in Kolkata in 1974. Through its field programmes, training and research, the focus of the NGO has been on health of women and children, child nutrition and development, adolescent issues and mainstreaming street children through education. *Child Rights and You (CRY)* is another prominent NGO that catalyses change in the lives of underprivileged children in India by restoring their rights.

There are also many NGOs focussing on the welfare of women. *Centre for Social Research* is a non-governmental organisation whose mission is to empower the women and girls of India, guarantee their fundamental rights, and increase understanding of social issues from a gender perspective. The NGO operates on local, national and regional levels in an effort to enhance the capacities of individuals, communities and institutions for creating a humane, equitable and gender-just society. *Sapna* is another NGO that among other activities, is also engaged in women's empowerment.

Centre for Science and Environment is an NGO that researches into, lobbies for and communicates the urgency of development that is both sustainable and equitable. The efforts of the Centre are built around five programmes that include Communication for Awareness, Research and Advocacy, Education and Training, Knowledge Portal and Pollution Monitoring. *Kalpavriksh* is an NGO that works on environmental awareness, campaigns, litigation, research, and other areas.

All the NGOs have a strong information base and have information communication in its area of work as a mandate. They bring out reports and other publications such as magazine that are a source of information. Many NGOs work on unique projects and activities, and consequently the information products based on their activities are a primary source of information.

6.13 SUMMARY

Institutions as a source of information have been discussed in this Unit. As can be understood, there are different kinds of institutions and each of them has different functions. Nevertheless, they are an important source of information that meets the information requirement of different types of information seekers. While the documentary sources are valuable, the importance of institutions as a vital non-documentary source of information cannot be overlooked.

6.14 ANSWERS TO SELF CHECK EXERCISES

- 1) UNESCO, WHO, FAO, and IDRC are some of the important international agencies. United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization (UNESCO), founded in 1945 is a specialised agency of United Nations that promotes international cooperation among its 193 Member States and six Associate Members in the fields of education, science, culture and communication. UNESCO serves as a clearing house – for the dissemination and sharing of information and knowledge - while helping Member States to build their human and institutional capacities in diverse fields.
- 2) A learned society is an organisation that exists to promote an academic discipline or group of disciplines. Activities of learned societies include holding regular conferences for the presentation and discussion of new research results and publishing or sponsoring academic journals in their respective disciplines. Some also act as professional bodies, regulating the activities of their members in the public interest or the collective interest of the membership of the society. Several societies bring out information sources such as journals and abstracting services. The general nature of activities of the learned society, its knowledgeable members and the information resource base make a learned society an indispensable source of information.
- 3) A museum is a building or institution which houses a collection of artifacts. Museums collect and take care of objects of scientific, artistic, or historical importance and make them available for public viewing through exhibits that may be permanent or temporary. Museums undertake several activities that make them an important information source. This includes, display of objects, arts and artifacts along with its information; screening of educational films; guided tours; talks by the experts; special lectures and training programmes; facilities for photography; access to the reserve collection; library for the study; and advice on identification of art objects. These are all information providing activities of the museum.

6.15 KEYWORDS

- ACS** : American Chemical Society (ACS) is a premier learned society that publishes the important abstracting service, *Chemical Abstracts*.
- Archive** : An archive is a collection of historical records.
- IASLIC** : Indian Association of Special Libraries and Information Centres (IASLIC) is a learned society that has many library professionals of special libraries and information centres as members.
- Museum** : A museum is a building or institution which houses a collection of artifacts.
- Right to Information Act** : An Act that mandates timely response to citizens' requests for government information.
- UNESCO** : United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization (UNESCO) is a specialised agency of United Nations that promotes international cooperation in the fields of education, science, culture and communication.
- WHO** : World Health Organization (WHO) is an institution providing leadership on global health matters, shaping the health research agenda, setting norms and standards, articulating evidence-based policy options, providing technical support to countries and monitoring and assessing health trends.

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UNIT 7 MEDIA AS SOURCES OF INFORMATION

Structure

- 7.0 Objectives
- 7.1 Introduction
- 7.2 Media
- 7.3 Mass Media
 - 7.3.1 Characteristics, Scope and Functions
 - 7.3.2 Positive Influences
 - 7.3.3 Negative Influences
- 7.4 Components of Mass Media
 - 7.4.1 Print Media
 - 7.4.2 Radio Broadcasting
 - 7.4.3 Television
 - 7.4.4 Recordings on such as CD, DVD, etc.
 - 7.4.5 Motion Films
- 7.5 Accessibility and Availability
- 7.6 Advertisements
- 7.7 Public Relations
- 7.8 Indian Scenario
- 7.9 ICT and Mass Media
- 7.10 Media Persons as Sources of Information
- 7.11 Summary
- 7.12 Answers to Self Check Exercises
- 7.13 Keywords
- 7.14 References and Further Reading

7.0 OBJECTIVES

After reading this Unit, you will be able to:

- discuss media as an instrument of social transformation;
- describe mass media, their components, scope and functions;
- explain the influence of mass media on the society;
- identify the various sources of accessibility to and availability of mass media information such as printed sources, Internet, mobile phones;
- highlight the role and functions of advertisements and public relations being an integral part of mass media;
- describe the Indian mass media scenario and their all round impact;
- state the importance of ICT in mass media; and
- explain how media persons can be vital sources of information.

7.1 INTRODUCTION

This Block deals with non-documentary sources of information. Under this category of sources, this Unit introduces you to mass media, which includes both print and electronic sources. Media themselves, as most powerful technological forces, are the principal instruments of changes in modern society; they impact every field of human activities. Mass media are means of communication such as newspapers, radio, TV through which most people get their news, information and entertainment. They are powerful means of communication for shaping public opinion and determine public policy of government, business and industry and other institutions. They purvey every natural phenomenon and practically all human events and activities.

In this Unit, you will get an exposure to all components of mass media, which will include print and electronic media. In today's context, 'mass' includes every section of the society, irrespective of their status or knowledge perceptions. Hence, mass media impact every section of society in one-way or the other. We will understand the scope, functions and activities of newspapers, radio broadcasting, TV, motion films, and also recordings, which carry stored information in CDs and DVDs. All these activities are through well-established institutions, managed by qualified and experienced professionals.

Mass media generate a huge volume and variety of information and knowledge, which are vital sources for contemporary and historical studies. Accessibility to this treasury of information and knowledge in printed and/or in electronic form is available through a variety of secondary products and services which are organised and stored in libraries and information centres.

A normal feature today to access mass media information is through the Internet, and websites. Mobile phones also have become another effective media to provide accessibility to and availability of information as the Internet does. All mass media are inexorably intertwined with advertisements and involve public relation activities.

Advances in IT are continuously being applied in all the programmes of mass media namely, print, radio broadcasting, TV, motion films and in every other form of electronic media. Indian mass media has a fine record of history. Currently they have expanded phenomenally in all directions. An overview of the Indian scenario is presented in this Unit. Persons associated with mass media are intellectual, managerial and technical people having a variety of skills and experiences. In the following sections of this Unit, we will make a detailed study of all these aspects mentioned above.

7.2 MEDIA

In this Unit, media refer to the mass media communication such as newspapers, magazines, radio, television, recordings of audio-visual aids like CD, DVD, etc. which are vital sources of information of mass communication. The impact of media has totally transformed human life in modern societies. They are not just the carriers of information and knowledge *per se* but also the means by which they have been communicated are the main cause of the sea changes in society, which is heading towards a 'Knowledge Society'. However, in this Unit, we are confining ourselves only with mass media communication.

In this context, it is appropriate to recall the slogan, “Medium is the Message” coined by Marshall McLuhan. This message implies that the carrier of communication whether human voice, image or text – influences the message, the sender, the audience. Today, every human intellectual output can be carried through a complex, integrated, intermixed and interactive system resulting in the integration of data, text, image, voice by the application of advances in ICT that are the root cause of societal changes. We are confining ourselves in this Unit to mass media, and their ramifications as important information sources.

Self Check Exercise

Note: i) Write your answer in the space given below.

ii) Check your answer with the answers given at the end of this Unit.

- 1) How does media influence communication and cause changes in society as conceived by McLuhan?

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7.3 MASS MEDIA

Mass media is defined “as the institutions of public communication that have as their physical channel of transmission a mass medium – television, radio, motion pictures, newspapers, books, music and recordings. It is these institutions and organisations that use print and electronic devices to produce contents for use of audiences. When mass medium becomes the channels in mass communication, they bring three characteristics to the process namely:

- 1) A complex technology becomes involved;
- 2) The velocity of the process increases in order to reach a huge audience; and
- 3) The amplitude increases because the potential to be read, heard or viewed, is powerful.” (Hiebert 1988)

Mass communication is the process whereby mass-produced messages are transmitted to large, anonymous and heterogeneous audiences. The word ‘mass’ refers to people in a large number. The large number, usually, indicates or implies mostly to the lower strata of society who are unlettered or ignorant in many ways. But in today’s context, ‘mass’ includes every section of the society, irrespective of their status or knowledge perceptions. Apart from laypersons, they include a wide audience of scholars, professionals, scientists, artists, musicians, in fact, every group, young and old. Mass media serve the interests of individuals and groups. It is so because today mass media offer services informing people about current events, and every significant natural phenomenon and such other information of common public interest.

Mass media generate a vast amount of information and knowledge. Apart from the volume generated, the variety, every subject of human interest, programmes mirroring life of societies, reporting every natural phenomena, etc. make the generated information a virtual treasure. In fact, mass communication appears to be giving a running commentary of human events and activities that are continuously recorded to make them invaluable sources for studying the contemporary life of a society and are worthy of preservation for historical studies.

Self Check Exercise

Note: i) Write your answers in the space given below.

ii) Check your answers with the answers given at the end of this Unit.

2) What does mass mean in today's context of mass communication?

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3) Why is information and knowledge generated by mass media worth preservation?

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7.3.1 Characteristics, Scope and Functions

Mass media offer a current awareness service, e.g. instantaneous service, like reporting of current events and activities by radio and television. Radio and television are faster means of communication than the print media such as newspapers. They are inextricably so interwoven with modern society that one cannot survive without the other. They are purveyors of information; providers of pleasure and enjoyment; changers of perception and behaviour.

The newspaper industry is in the private sector and enjoys considerable freedom. It is regarded as the **Fourth Estate** that shapes, influences, and indirectly govern public affairs in a democratic set-up, although it has no constitutional authority to control the affairs of a state.

There are instances in recent years where mass media, including the press, have played a vital role in delivering justice. There have been a number of examples wherein the mass media have been instrumental in creating public opinion about several criminal cases, which has led to speedy justice. Thus, media play an important role in publicising cases which require public attention. All media are expensive and need huge organisations to collect, process, formulate and disseminate information, views, entertainment to enormous, scattered, heterogeneous audiences simultaneously.

They encompass almost all conceivable subjects to include everything of interest to the audiences such as news of current events and activities, art and music, language and literature, science and technology, business and industry, travels and tourism, transport and communication, computers and telecommunication and so forth.

Information contained in mass media has very important archival value, as they are invaluable primary sources for recording contemporary history. Their functions are to inform, educate, instruct, motivate, persuade, influence, mould or shape, entertain and sell information to large audiences. They generally absorb intellectuals and researchers and persons of academic perceptions and scholarship, besides expert technologists, technicians and managers and professionals.

Self Check Exercise

Note: i) Write your answers in the space given below.

ii) Check your answers with the answers given at the end of this Unit.

4) What are the characteristics of mass media?

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5) State the type of persons involved in mass media.

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7.3.2 Positive Influences

Information disseminated by mass media has a direct impact on society. An account of its extensive reach, particularly to urban audiences, mass media have become so central to society that it is inconceivable that without mass media today, societies can function. They inform and shape social life, particularly the younger generation, to develop into good and responsible citizens. Their impact and influence is positive if they are able to fulfil the information and entertainment needs of people in accordance with the norms of social values and culture.

By and large, the information disseminated by mass media and their programmes is positive. They are pro-communal harmony, anti-environmental pollution, support national integration, anti-drug addiction, advocate health care and safety, demonstrate benefits of yogic exercises for healthy life, create peace for economic prosperity, anti-terrorism and social evils, generally educative and instructive, giving helpful guidance to children and young adults, etc. As a matter of policy and principle, information dissemination and the programmes of mass media conform to government regulations, code of ethics and legal norms.

7.3.3 Negative Influences

The foremost importance in reporting is that the information reported is collected from authentic and credible sources, and nothing should ever be misinterpreted. But this principle is quite often overlooked.

The very nature of mass media being persuasive, may result in the media transcending ethical codes within which they are expected to perform and may become biased, manipulative and propagandist. It is not uncommon for a political party or an agency to manipulate reports in their favour, which would indicate political control. Biased reporting can occur to obtain a favourable result. A journalist or a reporter may bring her/his personal preference on an issue to support a political party. A particular event or celebrity may receive undue importance and set youths to incorrect practices. It may present ostentatious lifestyle, which may inculcate wrong ideals amongst youngsters.

Unnecessary sensationalism of an event of daily life may magnify its importance creating fear and panic among the public. Wrong interpretation of news may even blow up things out of proportion and create unrest or even violence at any time and place and pose a law and order problem. At times, a particular event or news item may receive too much attention because of the lack of important news to report. This would again present unnecessary and avoidable tension amongst the public.

As long as the mass media give what people need or want, they remain a potent force in society. But the moment they, with acquired power and control, give what they think people want, they become manipulative and start working towards influencing the minds of people, leading to indoctrination. This applies to every programme they present. Therefore, if mass media are to become credible instruments of social change, they have to function with restraints and responsibility in accordance with established regulations, codes, conventions and practices.

We have studied, so far, the general aspects of mass media and their ramifications, indicating their value as important sources of information.

Self Check Exercise

Note: i) Write your answer in the space given below.

ii) Check your answer with the answers given at the end of this Unit.

6) Briefly state the positive norms of mass media.

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7.4 COMPONENTS OF MASS MEDIA

In this section we shall study the components of mass media in detail. Mass media, both print and electronic, comprise predominantly the following:

- Print Media
- Radio Broadcasting
- Television
- Recordings on such as CD, DVD, etc.
- Motion Films

7.4.1 Print Media

Print media of mass communication comprises of newspapers, popular magazines and periodicals, trade journals, posters, leaflets, books, in particular paperbacks and other printed materials. Of these, newspapers, magazines and periodicals are most extensively used.

Two notable developments in the Indian context witnessed in newspaper industry are commercialisation and the introduction of information and communication technologies. Beginning from the fifties there has been a rapid growth of newspaper industry to withstand the challenges and fierce competition from the newer electronic media, particularly, radio and television. They have adopted the latest information and communication technology in their production process, to speed up their production and circulation and improve their physical get up. This is required to face the competition of the electronic media. On account of commercialisation, the competition among the newspapers themselves has been stiff which has not only aided their sales but also improved the quality of production.

Daily newspapers are the most predominant ones among the print media; they have large circulation and wide audiences. In India, newspapers are published in most of the regional languages and they also have very large circulation. Some of the top newspaper agencies publish their dailies from different cities in multiple editions to focus attention on regional news, events and activities. Sunday editions carry weekly magazines, special advertisements, and other supplements.

Scope, Coverage and Functions

Large newspapers have their own mechanisms to get news through their own reporters from different parts of the country and also from foreign countries, in addition to their contracts with news agencies, (national and international), for the supply of news and information. Almost all newspapers have their websites to get instantaneous news round the clock. They are also accessible through the Internet.

Everyday the dailies publish one or more supplements on specific topics such as education and training, economics, industry, business and trade, science and technology, sports and games, art, entertainment, and music. There are also newspapers exclusively specialising in economics, sports and games, films, TV programmes, music, business and trade, employment, government memoranda and orders and the like.

The print media, newspapers in particular, have the greatest advantage that they can be used with ease and convenience. Newspaper can be easily carried and can be read anywhere, at anytime.

Generally, the daily newspapers carry news, commentaries and analysis on political, economic, social topics on current events, personalities, feature articles of subjects of current topical interests, general information on weather, business information, share market data and analysis, local programmes and events, sports and games, films and such other topics of public interest. Editorial on current specific topics are a daily feature, except on Sundays, which have a very special value as they express views and comments in consonance with the general policy of the newspaper.

Weekly editions of newspapers carry feature articles on various topics of public interest contributed by well known journalists and column writers. Reviews of films, books, arts, paintings, music, etc. are also published. There are review articles which are contributed by specialists in the field and hence are very authentic.

For those who prefer light reading material, there is a great variety of jokes and humor, fun, cross-word puzzles, quizzes, comics and satire, including something that interests the children. We have already mentioned that newspapers as a mass media, function to inform, educate, instruct, motivate, influence, persuade, entertain, etc.

As sources of information, newspapers have the highest archival value as they form the primary sources for recording contemporary history. Modern libraries and information centres preserve them in microforms and /or in digital form. They are virtually current awareness services, reporting current events and activities all round the world, carry news on every significant natural phenomenon and focus on a wide audience.

Among the mass media, newspapers have the highest credibility, among the other mass media, in terms of authenticity, collecting news and information from dependable sources, comments and analysis current events contributed by persons of reputation and eminence in public affairs.

Self Check Exercise

Note: i) Write your answers in the space give below.

ii) Check your answers with the answers given at the end of this Unit.

7) What are the components of mass media?

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8) What do daily editions of newspapers usually carry?

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Constraints

Some of the constraints of newspapers are: 1) only literates can make use of them; 2) they are highly urban-based, nothing much of interest to rural folks; 3) prices of newspapers are not within the reach of the most economically weaker section of the society. As a result, their circulation suffers considerably. However one interesting factor is that, there is a practice in India among the economically weaker sections, a literate person reads newspaper columns aloud before a small group of six to eight persons, thus increasing the readability number of newspapers. This practice compensates for low circulation statistics improving the readability factor slightly.

Structure and Management of Newspaper Institutions

The newspapers institutions are well structured and well managed through a complex organisation and functioning. Usually the operations are divided into four major blocks, viz. news and editorials, administration, business, and production.

Although the most important of the four blocks is the editorial wing in our context, the other blocks are equally important. The business manager is in charge of promoting, selling, and proper distribution of newspapers. Advertisements are the vital lung of all mass media, without which mass media cannot function. A large share of the pages of newspaper carries various types of advertisements. The business manager is in charge of advertisements. The administration takes care of the maintenance function as well as finance and personnel management. The production block takes care of printing the newspaper and to maintain its physical quality.

As noted earlier, newspapers institutions have a well-qualified staff. They comprise of journalists with good academic and professional background and high proficiency in writing reports with speed and fine drafting quality. There are language and content editors, external column writers who write regularly, high level production staff and managers. These persons have special skills and constitute very good human information sources. Most of the large newspaper organisations have a library and an archival unit. Some of newspapers have a well organised indexing and retrieval systems of their own newspapers for internal use.

Application of Modern Printing Technology

As already mentioned, large newspapers have been applying computer-based printing technology for production. Computer typesetting, desktop publishing software for layout and page making, introducing colour and elegant presentation, transferring the set matter to sensitive metal plates and using these plates for printing are the modern means of production. Thus the production speed has been achieved, in a clean and spic and span office environment with much less noise and the printing block has a very different look from the earlier methods and days of printing. Modern means of transportation and distribution have also helped in speedy circulation.

Magazines and Periodicals

Another class of print media of mass communication is magazines and popular periodicals, which also reflect the functions and activities of societies all over the world. Magazines and periodicals are popular publications issued periodically, usually in paper cover, typically containing stories, essays, poems, etc. by many writers, they may be general, political, economic, social and other subjects of public interest or in specifically in a subject like business and trade, sports and games, music, cinema, religion and philosophy, etc. They can be specially oriented towards subjects of interests of women, children and men. Most often they are of light reading nature but periodicals like *Economist* carry writings of serious nature, which are even cited in learned periodicals. Typical examples in English are *Readers Digest*, *Life*, *Time Magazine*, *Fortune*, (US Publications) *Economist*, (England) *India Today*, *Outlook*, (Indian), etc. which are very popular and have wide circulations.

Magazines and periodicals comprise mostly of weeklies, monthlies but also include bi-monthlies, quarterlies. Special annual editions are not uncommon. These types of publications are in every Indian language and have regional orientation and widely read. They bring out festival editions, which may be their annual features. Many of the house journals and newsletters of institutions are also of this nature. These types of publications have increased phenomenally in recent decades and also have wide circulations and various types of audiences, as newspapers. They are also valuable source materials, for contemporary historical writings.

Modern printing technology is used in the production. They are physically quite attractive, printed colour photographs and pictures on glossy paper with beautiful outer covers. They are distributed through their agents in different parts of the country and usually displayed in news-stands where single issues can be bought. They are also carry advertisements which support their publication costs.

Many of these magazines and periodicals are indexed in secondary publications and are available in the electronic form also. Most of them have their websites and can be accessed through the Internet. They have archival value as newspapers are preserved in libraries and information centres in microforms and/or digitised forms.

Self Check Exercise

Note: i) Write your answer in the space given below.

ii) Check your answer with the answers given at the end of this Unit.

9) Why are periodicals and magazines considered useful information sources?

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7.4.2 Radio Broadcasting

Electronic media, comprising of radio, television, satellite TV, cable TV, motion films, recordings, etc. is distinctly different from print media, as it provides news and information instantaneously. It is essentially entertainment media but has many other features, which are both instructive and informative. It carries information across distances and to the masses that are geographically, culturally, intellectually and emotionally separated from one another. It is the fastest media much quicker than print media. Its impact on audiences is decisively much greater than print media. In this section, we shall discuss the characteristics, scope, coverage and impact of radio broadcasting. It is also a valuable sources of information of mass media as much as print media.

Characteristics, Scope and Functions of Radio Broadcasting

The radio is an aural medium; there are no visuals. It is a sightless medium. Its impact, therefore, is less than visual media, very much less than audio-visual media. Its success has to be achieved only through voice of the announcers, newsreaders, and performers in a play, music and sound effects. Notwithstanding these limitations, radio has been a success before the advent of television.

As sound and voice of participants in the various programmes of radio broadcasting are the physical aural media, persons with voices suitable for broadcasting are very carefully selected through audition tests. Radio listeners must be aware that, in the past, some of the best newsreaders, announcers, anchor persons of programmes, and such other participants who have excellent voice, articulation abilities and such other skills have left a lasting impressions.

The appeal and impact is achieved through voices suitable for microphones, delivery with voice modulations, accents and emphasis on words and phrases, tonal variations, sensible pauses. These are some of the essential skills required for good broadcasting. With good, artistic and musical sound effects, some of the radio programmes have been hits.

The language of the scripts is another important characteristic of radio programmes. The contents have to be user friendly, written by persons who have a good command over the language and written in an appealing style as required in different contexts.

A radio set or a transistor is far cheaper than a TV. The portable quality of transistors makes it possible to listen to radio programmes anywhere, at home, at work places, in office premises, at a picnic spot, at bedside, etc.

Radio is a medium of immediacy. It can report events almost instantaneously, as they happen. The reporting staff of radio station can reach the place of events immediately and start disseminating news of the event. It takes more time for TV crew to reach the spots of the events and set everything to take shots and operate. Radio is, therefore, much quicker in reporting such events.

Self Check Exercise

Note: i) Write your answer in the space given below.

ii) Check your answer with the answers given at the end of this Unit.

10) Describe why the radio broadcasting has been more successful vis-a-vis TV programmes.

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Scope, Coverage and Functions

The portable radio set has become a constant companion to farmers who listen to farm bulletins; workers for recreation; travelers for various information and such others. Because of low costs of radio transistors, broadcasting reaches quite far and wide, particularly to the poorer sections of people, living in remote places. Programmes of right mix of news, music, talks on specific issues public interests, running commentaries on sports and games events, etc. interspersed with well addressed commercials are quite successful in attracting listeners.

Radio stations broadcast news round the clock, give periodical summaries of news, reviews and analysis and critical comments on current events and activities, entertainment programmes of various public interests like music, serials, plays, several programmes of interest to special groups such as women, children, farmers, industrialists, and many others. Thus, broadcasting has entertained listeners for several decades from the beginning of twentieth century.

Like newspapers, radio as a mass media, functions to inform, educate, instruct, motivate, influence, persuade, entertain, etc. to the extent it can compete with other media, possibly with greater effect on the audience than print media.

Like advertisements sustain the newspaper industry; radio broadcasting also thrives on numerous aural advertisements which are quite attractive because of the sonorous voice of the speakers.

Structure and Management of Radio Broadcasting

There are three major components in the structure and organisation of radio viz., the local station, the networks and the programme execution, operations and presentation. There are a variety of radio networks and agencies providing an array of programme services, including music, sports, features, and commentaries. Like the newspaper, the structure of radio broadcasting organisation is complex, requiring a variety of expertise of several specialists and professionals, specialists in radio journalism.

Radio broadcasting services are offered mostly by private sectors. Until recently, in India, Akashvani was the only government sector involved in this business, but now private sectors are also offering broadcasting services, introducing the element of competition to market their services.

The personnel in radio broadcasting include producers, directors, programme specialists of different categories besides artists, musicians, scriptwriters, engineers and technologists, newsreaders and commentators. Invariably, it is teamwork and astute team management in terms of producing, best programmes. Many external experts and professionals contribute in programme planning, execution and production.

The use of satellites for programme distribution, multimedia access through the Internet and websites, the rise of broadcast technology particularly digital audio broadcasting and its widespread use not only have added to programme options but have also improved radio stations ability to give quality, besides controlling costs and stay in media business despite fierce competition from TV.

Archives of radio stations have stocked a very large number of recorded cassettes and CDs, of speeches of eminent persons, programme events, music, etc. providing invaluable source materials for contemporary and historical studies and organising a variety of useful programmes of past activities.

Self Check Exercise

Note: i) Write your answer in the space given below.

ii) Check your answer with the answers given at the end of this Unit.

11) State briefly the archival value of radio broadcasts.

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7.4.3 Television

Of the electronic media of mass communication, the most powerful and influential media having impact on society is the Television (TV). Borrowing certain features from the earlier media of communication like the theatrical stage, the film and the radio, it has amalgamated them into a new media with its own identify. For example, from stage it has borrowed movement, from the film the camera and from the radio the microphone, integrating all these into a unique medium, quite different from the other media, thoroughly telegenic i.e. most suitably attractive to be displayed on the screen. In nature, in idiom of expression and receptivity, arithmetic communication, it is distinctly different from the other media. This section deals with some of these matchless characteristic features of TV, its scope, coverage and functions.

Characteristic Features of TV

Television occupies a dominant position in our lives with its multi-dimensional attractive features. Despite its dominant position in our lives, it is still young, fast growing and developing with the rapidly advancing information and communication technology. TV's sweeping dimensions can be gauged by the lively pictures it brings with camera, man walking on the moon, visuals of planets, telecasts of living creatures under sea or ocean, magnificent stars in the sky. We are able to see live telecast of Gulf War, natural disasters like earthquake or tsunami, terrorists' attacks all over the world, world cup soccer or cricket played in any part of globe and other events and activities almost instantaneously. People who could never know or even imagine the affluence of western life, are able to witness through TV the amazingly rich life of people there. Eminent persons of the world, their public performances and speeches are heard daily by the ordinary folks of villages. Thus, TV impacts its audiences so strongly that it has led to many societal changes both desirable and undesirable.

Many of the TV programmes are highly informative, instructive, expands our perceptions and knowledge, and indeed very educative. These positive features could be used effectively to change the entire mode of learning, making people more knowledgeable and contribute to better living conditions. TV entertainment features are numerous and people are glued to TV to view soap operas, serials with various social, and cultural themes, music, classical and light, various types of dances, quiz programmes for young persons and many others. Interestingly, TV programmes are so attractive that have made people even neglect their important responsibilities and commitments to give exclusive time to watch TV. All age groups watch these programmes, without the distinction of gender, although every group has its own choices.

To keep well informed of current events and activities, there are round the clock news bulletins, news analysis, interviews, panel discussions on political, economic and social issues, live telecasts of various tournaments of games and sports. Thus, these kinds of programmes are endless, covering practically every subject of human interest. Like the newspapers and radio broadcasting, TV functions to inform, educate, instruct, motivate, influence, persuade, entertain, etc. with much greater force of impact on society than either newspapers or radio.

TV Channels

There are hundreds of TV channels, telecasting twenty four hours, seven days a week (24X7). In English language alone, there are scores of channels operating in India, with sub channels exclusively devoted to news, movies, serials, sports and games, etc. The programmes of these channels are listed in the daily newspapers for viewers to make their selective choices and prepare their schedule for watching them. Besides these English channels, there are language channels almost in every Indian language, more than one, in fact, making it bewildering for the viewers to choose from to make their watching schedules. These language channels also have their sub channels devoted exclusively to news, serials, motion films, etc. Apart from these types of channel distribution, there are English channels specialising in world news, wildlife, cartoons, fashions, life style, movies, sports and games, real estate, etc. Some of the popular channels of this class are NDTV, BBC, National Geographic, CNN, ESPN, Zee TV, Sony TV, and such others.

Commercialisation of TV is in its zenith with advertisements forming a major share of the time of programmes, in fact, in every TV show, including news, nearly fifty per cent of its time is given to advertisements. Some of the live telecasts such as Soccer Leagues, World Cup Tournaments, Cricket Twenty 20, One Day Internationals are money spinners for some of the TV channels. As a result of commercialisation of TV, there is a fierce competition among channels. Until recently Doordarshan had the monopoly of TV in India but now a number of private channels, English and language ones, besides the international channels, have come up, posing a severe challenge to Doordarshan to compete in the market.

Cable TV

Cable TV is another dimension of TV media with advances in ICT. Satellite and fiber optics communication have opened up to viewers to a number of internal and external TV channels. Cable TV is operated by linking the viewers' TV sets through cables to a common antenna. It is operated through a dish antenna and from a control room. The dish antenna, placed in a particular angle, can catch signals from broadcasting services like Doordarshan or foreign services like Star TV, CNN, BBC, MTV, Prime Sports, etc. These broadcasts can be relayed through cable to individual customers of a cable operator. Cable operators also provide what is generally called 'domestic TV'. In this service, they show films and other programmes according to the demands of their customers. The customers are charged for laying the cable and also a monthly fee. The fee or rent would depend on the cost of providing the service, quality of the service, number of channels made available to customers and such others.

Cable TV has become so popular among viewers that along with video cassettes, it is increasingly being used by political parties, especially during elections. Industrialists, business persons and professionals like medical doctors, architects, consultants and such others also have started using these media.

Non-Broadcast TV Channels

In the international context, there are also non-broadcast television channels. Educational institutions were among the first users of non-broadcast television, using video to communicate both internally and externally. Business and industry

are major users of non-broadcast video. Some of the other institutions in non-broadcasting TV are government agencies, social service agencies, professional organisations, production houses, medical and health organisations, religious groups. The Red Cross has studios in Washington D.C. (USA) where it produces a variety of tapes on such topics as blood donation and disaster relief. Hospitals, clinics, medical schools, and individual physicians use these video programmes in numerous ways. Plastic-surgery technology is documented by a hospital in Springfield, Illinois (USA) for distribution to other hospitals and surgeons. Despite increasing competition and criticism, television today is a huge, complex, expensive, continuous and competitive medium. It is society's mass entertainer, mass informer, mass persuader, and mass educator. It is a universal medium.

TV Archives

The information and knowledge generated by TV is a veritable source of information for all kinds of contemporary writings such as political and economic analysis, consolidation of many current events and activities, trend reports in many fields, etc. Archives of TV channels, TV networks like Doordarshan and others are mine of information source for contemporary and historical studies.

The kind of expertise, special knowledge and skills required to produce captivating, informative, instructive and knowledgeable TV programmes can be easily imagined. Designers, developers, scriptwriters, technicians and technologists, artists, musicians, photographic artists, camerapersons and numerous other specialists involved in TV are invaluable resource persons.

7.4.4 Recordings on such as CD, DVD, etc.

Recordings here refer to audio, video and audio-visual reproductions on magnetic tapes or discs as well as on laser tapes. They are all part of the home entertainment environment which gives consumers direct control over what, where, when they view or listen to them.

Among the many record media of mass communication, are the video cassettes, CD-ROMs and DVDs (Digital Versatile/Video Discs) that are most influential. They are highly user friendly and closely linked with individual and group use. Most of these audio-visual media are designed with great care and the audio support enhances their value to a very great extent.

The production of multimedia CD-ROMs and DVDs is a complex and intricate affair. Many types of specialists are necessary to produce a good video programme either for entertainment, news commentaries or analysis, learning kits, course materials for distance education and many others. Screen scriptwriters, design and development experts, production and marketing experts and a host of others are normally involved in the production of audio-visual items.

The technologies applied are varied and complex. The complexity increases particularly with the multimedia used for producing audio-visuals. The marketing of these types of media is again a work of specialists. They are commercial ventures of high investment in terms of finance, manpower of quality and production.

CD-ROMs and DVDs are extremely valuable for archival purposes as sources of information. They occupy very little space. Reference materials like encyclopaedias and other types of reference works are preserved in these media and stocked in libraries. There are also private or commercial video libraries that supply CDs and DVDs on hire, especially films.

It is said that the media is changing fast and will be more powerful in the future than it has been in the past, mainly because it puts control and time in the hands of the consumer.

Self Check Exercise

Note: i) Write your answer in the space given below,

ii) Check your answer with the answers given at the end of this Unit.

12) Why are TV channels, cable TV, recordings are so powerful in influencing society as compared to other media of mass communication?

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7.4.5 Motion Films

Motion films are an important medium of popular entertainment because of their wide mass appeal and influence on society. Combined with TV, films constitute the most powerful media that impacts every section of the audience in all possible ways. In India, with all its cultural and linguistic diversities and the problems of illiteracy, films are the most powerful of all media, cutting across the linguistic and cultural diversities with a universal emotional language. Commercial cinema is all charming and romantic and fanciful. The usual ingredients are songs, group dances, crime, fights, melodrama and comedy, all bordering on imagination and unreality. The idea of film makers, in general, is to prepare a show of popular entertainment to ensure financial success and box office hit.

Characteristic Features of Motion Films

Although every mass media is a team effort, a film is the most collaborative medium of much bigger magnitude than any other media. The huge financial investment, the number of persons involved, time required for shooting a film, complexity in production and distribution make it totally different from other media.

Hundred of persons collaborate to make a film in its production process. The group includes producer, director, story writer, dialogue writer, actors both male and female, specialist persons in various aspects such as art, music, dance, fights, illumination, sound, costumes, make-up, scene set up, cameras, etc. in making a film.

Thus a motion film is a product of interaction between technical and artistic persons. It uses many devices like cameras with several lenses, microphones, dubbing machines, editing or cutting machines, projectors, mixers, sound tracks, trolleys to mount cameras, celluloid, laboratory equipment, etc. The combined work of artists and technicians result in a sophisticated film of quality.

The director of a film is central to the success of a film. The director's artistic, aesthetic and technical skills will determine the quality of the film both in terms of its production and actors' performances. Some of the celebrated among film directors, to mention just a few are Hitchcock, Cecil D'Mello, in the international context and Satyajit Ray, Bimal Roy, Balachander, Mani Ratnam in the Indian context.

Apart from the entertainment value of films, it has also become an art medium today, just as painting, sculpture, architecture, drama, poetry and music. It has become, in fact, a discipline in its own right, in which scholars and intellectuals participate in its growth and development. Film training institutes have developed, treating film production as an academic and professional discipline.

Today films are considered an effective medium for development. Films can contribute modernising a traditional society into a modern society by helping to change the attitudes of people relating to work, gender, religion, customs, harmonious relationship among communities, beliefs, etc. Films can promote national integration by producing well thought out and relevant themes, proper direction and performance of artists.

Scope, Coverage and Functions of Functions of Motion Films

The scope of film production includes almost all subjects of human interest. Films have a universal acclaim and are a versatile means of communication. They include not only feature films for entertainment but also documentaries and newsreels. Feature films range from the sublime to the ridiculous to represent films of artistic and aesthetic tastes appealing to sophisticated intellectuals but also not so artistic ones to cater to the tastes of ordinary folks for fun and entertainment. In the Indian context, the coverage of films comprise mythological, religious, war, social, historical, patriotic, romantic, political, humorous themes, catering to the tastes of different kinds of audiences. With photographic tricks, camera lenses, shots from various angles, sound and light effects, music and dialogues, fight sequences, films create enchanting and exhilarating experiences and appeal emotionally to the audiences. Social and political films reflect contemporary events and activities of real life. Like the newspapers, radio broadcasting, TV, films also function to entertain, inform, educate, instruct, motivate, influence, persuade but with far more greater impact on the audiences than any other media.

Millions of cine goers simultaneously watch a film from different parts of the country, in cities, in towns and villages, as any number of copies of films can be made. A film can be transferred from celluloid to video cassette. The video cassette can be played at home through the video cassette recorder (VCR). The cable TV operators can transmit the film through a TV channel and a large number of their customers can view the film. So, a film can be viewed by a large number from different places at the same time. A film can also be seen again and again, any number of times. The inevitable result of watching films at home using VCR has reduced the number of people watching films in cinema halls which has naturally hit film's incomes.

Documentary Films

Documentary films have been universally recognised as another category of art films. A number of documentary films have been produced in India by the Films Division of the Government of India on themes of cultural interests and technical and informative films on different subjects. Documentary films have been produced on development projects and achievements, on persons of eminence in political, social, and cultural fields. Reputed producers and directors have brought out documentaries and short films on current issues of public interest, even in areas of controversial nature. Many of these documentaries have been screened at international film festivals and have been received well.

Film Industry

Although the film industry employs thousands of people, makes huge financial investments and yields lakhs of rupees to the government, it is still not recognised as an industry and not subject to the laws of industry. However there are a number of employees unions, guilds, associations which take care of their respective interests. The film industry is totally in the private sector with considerable freedom but subject to the censorship of the Central Board of Film Certification.

The Film Institute/Film and Television Institute of India houses the National Film Archives of India which stocks a number of Indian and foreign films. The training courses conducted by the institute have designed courses on the lines of the reputed French Film School in Paris. The students get a thorough grounding in the techniques of film production and also in the history and aesthetics of cinema. The National Film Archives is a great source of information and knowledge on all aspects of films which certainly is a great treasure for contemporary and historical studies on Indian social life and culture.

To sum up, national and international films, documentaries and short films are important components of mass media. They involve latest technology and an array of persons of various categories of technologists and technicians and intellectuals, actors and actresses, with supporting casts, camera persons, make-up artists, sound and illumination experts, lyricists, musicians and music directors, orchestra artists, editors, production experts, directors and a host of other categories of specialists. Excellent studios exist for indoor shooting. Outdoor shooting experts constitute another group of persons involved. The financial outlays in these types of media are almost astronomical and the market is highly competitive. Educational and training institutes and National Film Archives provide the necessary infrastructure for manpower development and supporting resources.

Self Check Exercise

Note: i) Write your answer in the space given below.

ii) Check your answer with the answers given at the end of this Unit.

13) What are the special features of films that make them different from other forms of mass media?

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7.5 ACCESSIBILITY AND AVAILABILITY

From the foregoing account, it is quite evident that mass media generate enormous amount of information and knowledge that are invaluable and versatile sources of information for contemporary and historical studies. Newspapers carry quite a lot of ephemeral information that may not be of much value. But nearly fifty per cent of information published in newspapers is worth preserving and useful for different studies. Similarly, magazines and periodicals also carry valuable information that is worth preserving.

Radio and television channels produce almost a running commentary on the life of the people in a variety of subjects. With the plethora of channels and vested interest of some of the channels, the information generated may lack credibility for preservation because of biased and distorted views. None the less, they broadcast a variety of programmes that reflect contemporary life of people and valuable to preserve at least in part. Live telecasts of current events and activities are of great value.

Films, as described earlier, are a mirror of contemporary life. They are produced in large numbers in India. The National Films Archives stock them for posterity. The films produced in the earlier decades of the twentieth century compared with current films will show the gulf of difference between the two in terms of the life of the people in every aspect then and now and advances in technology.

Therefore accessibility to and availability of mass media information and knowledge is an important national responsibility. Although there is no bibliographical control at the national level on the mass of information generated, many libraries and archives stock these materials and service them to scholars, researchers and students. Newspapers are preserved in microforms or digital forms in national libraries, university libraries and research libraries. Considering their value as records of contemporary human life, many countries have legal regulations for depositing books and newspapers and also motion films. Indian Delivery of Books and Newspapers Act has the provision for depositing books, periodicals and newspapers in the National Library, Kolkata, and three other libraries namely, Central Library, Mumbai, Connemara Public Library, Chennai and Delhi Public Library.

Newspapers like New York Times, London Times and some of the Indian newspapers like The Hindu, The Times of India and others have their own indexes in their archives. Newspaper clipping service is provided by some libraries and information centres for their internal users on specific topics.

Internet

The main focus of interest today is on the Internet for access to and availability of information and knowledge on any subject. Mass media is no exception. The Internet, as we all know, is a network of networks. Specifically, it is worldwide, publicly accessible, interconnected computer networks that transmit data using the standard Internet Protocol (IP). It consists of millions of smaller domestic, academic, business, mass media and governmental networks which together carry various information and services, such as electronic mail, online chat, file transfer, and the interlinked web pages and other documents of the World Wide Web. It enables distance learning through its new pattern of flexibility, contributing to reshaping of the knowledge environment and issues of access within it.

Contrary to common usage, the Internet and the World Wide Web (WWW) are not synonymous. The Internet is the system of interconnected computer networks; the Web is the contents or the interconnected documents, linked by hyperlinks and Universal Reference Locators (URLs). The WWW is accessible through the Internet, along with many other services including e-mail, file sharing and other such facilities.

The Internet is so versatile that it is fast becoming the centre of mass media. Every mass media, the newspapers, magazines and periodicals, radio broadcasting, television channels, motion films, etc. are accessible through the Internet. The Internet provides access to all primary information as well as secondary and/or tertiary information in the print or electronic media. Almost every newspaper Indian or foreign, national and international magazines and periodicals have their own web pages.

The limitations are that access to the Internet is restricted only to those who have access to computers with broadband facilities for using it for their information and knowledge, apart from barriers of illiteracy in India. This barrier is referred to as *Digital Divide* which practically denies the opportunity to access information to a major section of the community because of economic constraints or illiteracy.

Self Check Exercise

Note: i) Write your answer in the space given below.

ii) Check your answer with the answers given at the end of this Unit.

14) What are the limitations of the Internet?

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Mobile Phones

Developments in information and communication technologies (ICTs) while creating digital divide, offer the means of improving information delivery also to a large proportion of illiterate or semi-literate and marginalised communities. In fact, mobile phones are seen to bridge the digital divide in developed as well as developing countries. (Neelameghan, 2009).

Mobile phones or cell phones are long-range, electronic devices used for voice or data communication over a network of specialised base stations known as cell sites. In addition to the standard voice function of a mobile phone, current mobile phones support many additional services and accessories such as Short Message Service (SMS) for text messaging, e-mail, access to the Internet and many more. Similar to the Internet, mobile phone is also an interactive media has a wide reach. Practically all the Internet services and applications that exist or to have similar facilities on mobile phones. Many mobile media experts claim that mobile phones have several unique benefits that make it a more powerful media than either TV or the Internet. Mobile phones have the best audience accuracy and

are the only mass media with a built-in payment channel available to every user. Mobile phones are called the seventh mass medium with print, recordings, cinema, radio, TV and computer being the first six. Sometimes it is called the fourth screen, counting cinema, TV and computer screen as the first three or the third screen counting only TV and computer screens.

Prof. Neelameghan in his article on Mobile Phones discusses the role of ICT in networking among people at local, national and global levels, supporting the formation of communities of common interests and practices, sharing and exchanging information through mutual collaboration for common good. He cites research projects conducted in Karnataka which enables illiterates and marginalised communities to get information on their village professions through mobile phone facilities such as SMS and other communication techniques.

It is a common sight in cities and towns or even in villages to note how popular mobile phones are used among small traders and craftsmen in exchanging information in their respective trading and vocational activities. With all its current versatile facilities, and continuing research in wireless technologies, mobile phones would be a much more viable source of communication among farmers in villages, small traders and vocational communities and may break the barrier of marginalising the economically weaker communities and to a certain extent sorting out the problem of illiteracy through vernacular languages.

Self Check Exercise

Note: i) Write your answer in the space given below.

ii) Check your answer with the answers given at the end of this Unit.

15) What are the features of mobile phones that make it a unique physical media for inter communication?

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7.6 ADVERTISEMENTS

Advertising is defined as a paid dissemination of information through a variety of mass communication media to motivate a desired action. Advertisements are not free, they are to be paid for. Space is bought in the newspapers, magazines and periodicals in the print media or in recordings like CDs or DVDs, or time is bought in radio, TV and on the Internet. Through this payment for space or time, information is disseminated. This is not information for communicating information *per se* but for the process of selling or helping to sell commodities and services or gaining acceptance to ideas that may set people to think or act in a desired manner.

Modern advertising has emerged as the handmaid of industry. It is an outgrowth of mass production, mass market, mass distribution and mass communication. It keeps trade and commerce moving and helps the growth of the economy by creating demand for mass-produced goods and services.

Advertisements are very much an integral part of mass media and intimately connected with them today, basically for the following reasons because they:

- provide substantial financial support to mass media and *vice-versa*; the one cannot survive without the other;
- are viewed by many as a significant and rapidly developing industry, its practitioners facing challenges for creative and imaginative thinking to find out new and innovative methods and techniques to expand for occupying a major share of space in print media and time in radio and TV; and
- are a pervasive part of modern culture, a medium, among other things, for the construction of our images as well as of the society, mass media being the only most powerful and versatile avenue to achieve these objectives.

Advertising, publicity, propaganda marketing, public relations are near synonyms with their own shade of differences in meanings. Information disseminated through these methods, may occasionally be distorted, exaggerated, over emphasised but their objectives are to persuade, influence, motivate and/or they can get people to react favorably with regard to buying or selling a product or a service. The objectives of present mass media do not clash with business advertisements as they have a common commercial intent and motive in finding a market for their products and services. Advertisements have a larger share, in mass media, whether print or electronic, particularly in TV programmes, which demands most imaginative and innovative advertising methods for capturing the minds of people to react favorably towards a product or service. As advertisements are part of any programme in TV, radio, and in print media, which earns them a heavy revenue they have to be viewed or listened to compulsorily. The messages contained in advertisements are forms of communication that involve creativity, persuasion and impact. Advertisements carry impersonal messages which are controlled by a sponsor. By controlled we mean that the sponsor who pays for the messages of advertisements, determines the content.

Most of the advertisements are consumer-oriented. But the advertisements of trade, business-to-business, corporate houses are major part of the advertising industry. International advertisements are becoming increasingly important as more and more companies are engaging in global marketing through the Internet and web pages.

Advertisements have the following goals:

- Advertisers are advertising to help their customers to market their products and services;
- Advertising agents are specialised companies that plan and execute advertising campaign for most advertisers. Their work includes creation of advertisements, media planning and research; and
- Advertising media carry advertisements to consumers and mass media are dependent on advertising revenue.

Advertisements are conceived, given preliminary shape, altered and then finally executed. The entire work is a long process that includes situation analysis, setting objectives, evolve strategies and work out evaluation. The situation analysis includes research, leading to a definition of the advertiser's problem. The objectives of advertisements can range from creating an awareness to urging purchase, motivate and influence to accept a product or a service. Strategies and tactics are actions needed to achieve the objectives. Evaluation is the process of assessing whether or not the campaign achieved its expected goals.

Advertising agencies choose the media through which advertisements can be featured. Newspapers, magazines and periodicals and such other print media, give over 50 per cent of their pages to advertisements. This is particularly so in newspapers those have a huge circulation. Motions films, CDs and DVDs, video and audio cassettes, radio and TV and all other audio-video media provide a proportionately long time for advertisements.

It can be discerned that advertisements invariably require a variety of abilities and skills of the highest quality. Among these, some of the more important ones are imagination and creativity, ability to grasp consumer psychology, especially to design a directed action packed visuals and write effective short scripts to carry the desired messages, choose the right media which would influence or motivate the viewers to buy a product or a service, assess the impact of the advertisements, etc. In the case of audios and videos, duration of advertisements, the appropriate time of presentation, etc. are some of the important considerations. The advertisements for consumer markets will have to be constantly changed to attract attention of the viewers. These specialised types of work are nowadays generally entrusted to advertising agencies, which are carried out by separate departments wherein specialised persons are employed. The converging computer, communication and multimedia technologies are facilitators to the best advertisements.

Self Check Exercise

Note: i) Write your answer in the space given below.

ii) Check your answer with the answers given at the end of this Unit.

16) Why are advertisements an integral part of mass media?

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7.7 PUBLIC RELATIONS

According to the Institute of Public Relations, "Public Relations is the deliberate planned and sustained effort to establish and maintain mutual understanding between organization and its public. It is necessary, for the organization concerned to understand the public and relate the organization's activities to public interest."

Today every human activity is invariably organised through institutions. Many of these institutions are massive, such as a corporate enterprises, mass media establishments, both print and electronic, government affairs, etc. and involve in relations with a variety of persons or groups at various levels, with different interests and motivations, with varying economic, educational and cultural backgrounds. The contact organisations also have their own specific goals to achieve and have to conjure up an image to be successful in their endeavors. It is the Public Relation (PR) professionals that build an image for the organisation and sustain it. In this process public relations personnel will have to maintain the best of relations with the media. These involve media meetings at appropriate time, press releases of various types, preparation of special brochures, programmes, for TV and broadcasting, interviews with VIPs, design production of documentaries and so on. In turn, the media have also to maintain the best of relations with their contact organisations, in particular with advertising agencies to generate revenue, and with also their audiences to build their image and also to protect their interests.

For mass media to be successful in their enterprise, it is necessary for them to conduct research programmes to assess their audiences, the messages they spread and the impact of these messages on their different categories of audiences. The PR persons also can involve themselves in these activities. While advertisements promote marketing of goods and services, PR persons prepare the ground for such activities. Obviously, PR activities are vital and necessary for mass media.

Self Check Exercise

Note: i) Write your answers in the space given below.

ii) Check your answers with the answers given at the end of this Unit.

17) What is 'Public Relations'?

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18) Why is Public Relation necessary to mass media?

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7.8 INDIAN SCENARIO

In the Indian scenario, all the different mass media are functioning and operating quite well, generating valuable information and knowledge sources for contemporary and historical studies. All the characteristics and attributes described in the sections and the sub sections of this Unit on mass media are relevant in the Indian scenario without any exception.

Newspaper Media

Indian newspapers, magazines and periodicals have a good record in mass communication ever since they started functioning, in 2009 the total number of registered Indian language and English newspapers and periodicals were 73,146; 8,475 dailies, 383 tri/bi weeklies, 24,544 weeklies, 9,458 fortnightlies, 22,124 monthlies, 4,864 quarterlies and 653 annuals and 2,645 of other periodicity. The largest number of newspapers and periodicals registered were in Hindi, 29,094, the second largest in any language were in English (10,530) (India 2011).

The distribution figures of both Indian and English periodicals are also quite impressive, in fact they are increasing. All these newspapers have adopted modern methods of printing technology and their physical get-up, with colour photographs is quite attractive. Many of the English newspapers have multiple editions published from different metropolitan cities with daily supplements and weekly magazines.

The Press Information Bureau is the nodal agency of the Indian Central Government, that disseminates information on government policies, programme initiatives, and achievements. The Bureau disseminates information through press releases, press notes, feature articles, backgrounders, press briefings, photographs, press conferences, and interviews. The Feedback Cell of the Special Services of the Bureau has a Press Clippings Unit that caters to the requirements of the various ministries. A centralised press clipping service indexes the clippings with keywords with a search mechanism. Some of the university and research libraries stock newspaper files, and have selective newspaper clipping service. Some of the larger newspapers have their library and archives which may have their newspaper indexes for internal use.

Radio Broadcasting

The Broadcasting media, which started with All India Radio (now Akashvani) as a governmental agency in 1920s, has expanded considerably over the years with several areas of information service of public interest. About 100 private channels have been established by the Broadcasting Sector, making it both public and private broadcasting service. Akashvani has stations throughout the country in all the Indian languages, broadcasting news, music, other cultural and educational programmes. Akashvani news is also available on the Internet.

The Akashvani archives at New Delhi and in all its regional centres have a collection of CDs and audio cassettes which is a mine of information on various subjects which are invaluable source of information on current affairs, culture and many subjects of historical value.

TV Channels

Doordarsan has five national channels, eleven Regional Language Satellite channels, eleven Regional State Networks, 24 Regional News Units. Doordarsan has contributed significantly towards the acceleration of socio-economic change, promotion of national integration and stimulation of scientific temper in the country. Being a Public Service Broadcaster, its mandate is to carry through its programmes messages on population control and family welfare, preservation of environment and ecological balance, highlighting the need for social welfare measures for women, children and the less privileged. It is also mandated to promote games and sports and the artistic and cultural heritage of the country.

Doordarsan's monopoly was broken in 1992, when private channels infiltrated into the Indian boundaries through CNN, Star Plus, Zee TV, BBC, Sony International TV, MT, Discovery channel and a host of others. In addition, a number of Indian private channels in almost all the Indian languages and in English were launched. Today there are channels in every segment like music, entertainment, documentary, news, education, sports, comedy business, spiritual, regional and many others. Besides these channels, cable TV is another significant development. Cable operators offer a wide choice of channels and also CDs and DVDs of subscribers' choice of films, etc. The bewildering number of TV channels, generating a huge volume and variety of information, is overwhelmingly large. This poses a serious problem for preserving and retaining them in archives. More reliable and authentic would perhaps be those that are generated by Doordarsan and preserved in its archives.

Films

Indian cinema is almost a century old. Today, the Indian film industry produces more films than any other country. Indian films are very popular in West Asian countries, Pakistan and in many other countries. It remains the cheapest medium of entertainment for the masses. It is in the private sector.

We have described the importance, value and impact on the people of films as sources of information for historical and contemporary studies in some details in the earlier section on films in this Unit.

Film archives are invaluable and vital sources of information on Indian culture society, economy and political life. The Films Library of the Films Division of the Ministry of Information and Broadcasting is a treasure of valuable archival material of India's contemporary history, its heritage and artistic traditions. The total collection of film library, approximately 1.9 lakh items containing original picture negatives, a variety of positives and negatives prints. These items are stored in DVDs and also available in digitised form. The Films Library services are in great demand by film makers throughout the world. It contributes to the vital footage for the production of films besides bringing revenue through footage sale.

Films Division publicise and communicate support to the library collections, through documentaries, news magazines of video films for important campaigns like communal harmony, national integration, eradication of untouchability, family welfare programmes, etc.

The National Film Archives of India (NFAI) was established in 1964 as a media under the Ministry of Information and Broadcasting. The primary center of NFAI is to safeguard the heritage of Indian culture for posterity and act as a centre for dissemination of a healthy culture in the country. Promotion of scholarship and research on various aspects of cinema also form part of the objectives. Familiarising foreign audiences with Indian cinema and to make it more viable across the globe is another declared function of the NFAI.

Apart from its collection of Indian and foreign films, it has acquired over 30,000 film scripts, both Indian and foreign. Besides this, the archive library has a well stocked collection of approximately 25,000 books on cinema published across the globe. More than 100 Indian and foreign journals on cinema are available in the library.

Self Check Exercise

Note: i) Write your answers in the space given below.

ii) Check your answers with the answers given at the end of this Unit

19) Write a short note on the Indian mass media.

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20) Briefly discuss the importance and the national function performed by the Films Library and the National Films Archives of India.

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7.9 ICT AND MASS MEDIA

Research and innovation in information and communication technologies (ICTs) and mass media grow in tandem. Advances in ICT give unlimited scope for expansion in mass media in terms of round-the-clock programmes, innovation in design and development of new programmes, world-wide dissemination and transmission, etc. In short, ICT has facilitated a number of developments with far reaching implications for mass media. Every component of mass media, the print, broadcasting, TV and recording media use it with great effect and advantage.

The main focus today is on the Internet as a new, social sphere, facilitating new forms of economic, political and cultural exchange. It is multi-functional and cross-sectoral. It incorporates the World Wide Web and the e-mail. It involves

market, government, education, media and every societal sector. It is multimedia integrating visual, audio and textual material. It enables advances in distant learning, through a new pattern of flexibility, contributing to reshaping the knowledge environment and issues of access within it.

Commenting on the future trends, a media specialist observes, “the early twenty first century *mediascope* is significantly different from 50 years previously. Traditional media has shown resilience in adapting to a changing environment and in utilizing new technologies. For mass consumers the result is greater variety and expanding choice in the ways they access information and entertainment. The expansion and varied means of delivery have stimulated demand for content development for new media. A key question about converging and increasingly interactive media is whether users will gain access to genuinely novel and more varied forms of content – or whether there will be ‘more of the same.’ The pressures of commercialism suggest that innovation and experimentation will be circumscribed by profit-making imperatives.”

7.10 MEDIA PERSONS AS SOURCES OF INFORMATION

From the foregoing account of mass media and its components, it is possible to understand the usefulness of media specialists as vital resource persons in the areas of their specialisation. Some of the important factors that govern mass media processes are:

- Mass media operate in a highly commercial and competitive environment;
- This enjoins quality assurance on the products and services created/generated by mass media;
- Newspapers, periodicals, TV and radio programmes and many other media products of mass media have to operate within a strict time frame;
- This important factor necessitates that some of the media persons have to perform at great speed without compromising on quality; this accentuates their source credibility;
- The time element necessitates the media persons to keep their information ready for use at a short notice;
- Media work is a teamwork and every participant in them should fit into the team at the right place, as the output is a common objective; and
- Media persons’ expertise, experience and knowledge never get properly recorded and hence is not easily available.

Many groups of specialists are functioning in mass media, both print and electronic media. The institutions managing and operating these media may have to be contacted to get the assistance of media specialists as resource persons for any service.

Note: i) Write your answer in the space given below.

ii) Check your answer with the answers given at the end of this Unit.

21) Why are experts involved in mass media considered as invaluable resource persons?

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7.11 SUMMARY

This Unit attempts to give an exposure to information and knowledge generated by mass media as vital sources for contemporary and historical studies. Information and communication technologies offer unlimited opportunities for mass media to produce a variety of services, providing access to current events and activities. Mass media constitute both print media such as newspapers and periodicals, and electronic media that are radio, TV, recordings on audio and video CDs and DVDs, films, etc.

The electronic media, in particular, is very powerful in generating a host of programmes on every conceivable subject of human interest. The contents and messages of these media have tremendous impact on the people and are instrumental in changing the society in a number of ways. Media technologies are the primary cause for the changes in society because they permit multifarious presentations that appeal to the audiences. All these aspects of mass media that include their characteristics, scope, coverage, impact, influence and related aspects are discussed in this Unit. Advertisements and Public Relations (PR) are integral parts of mass media today. The ‘why and how’ of advertisements and PRs are functioning in mass media area described. In mass media a number of group of specialists contribute to the various programmes and activities. These specialists have very special skills and knowledge and can be highly useful as resource persons. The Indian mass media scenario is also presented to give a quick exposure.

7.12 ANSWERS TO SELF CHECK EXERCISES

- 1) According to McLuhan “Medium is the Message”. It implies that the carrier of communication whether human voice, image or text, digital – influences the message, the sender, the audience. Today, every human intellectual output can be carried through a complex, integrated, intermixed and interactive system resulting in the integration of data, text, image, voice with a single digital information environment by the application of advances in ICT that are the root cause of societal changes.
- 2) In today’s context, ‘mass’ includes every section of the society, irrespective of their status or knowledge perceptions. Apart from laypersons, they include a wide audience of scholars, professionals, scientists, artists, musicians, in

fact, every group, young and old. Mass media serve the interests of individuals and groups. It is so because today mass media offer services informing people about current events, and every significant natural phenomenon and such other information of common public interest.

- 3) Mass media generate a vast amount of information and knowledge. Apart from the volume generated, the variety, every subject of human interest, programmes mirroring life of societies, reporting every natural phenomena, etc. make the generated information a virtual treasure. In fact, mass communication appears to be giving a running commentary of human events and activities, which are continuously recorded to make them invaluable sources for studying the contemporary life of a society worthy of preservation for historical studies.
- 4) Mass media offer a current awareness service, e.g. instantaneous service, like reporting of current events and activities by radio and television. Radio and television are faster means of communication than the print media such as newspapers. They are so inextricably interwoven with modern society that one cannot survive without the other. They are purveyors of information; providers of pleasure and enjoyment; changers of perception and behaviour.
- 5) Mass media generally absorb intellectuals and researchers and persons of academic perceptions and scholarship, journalists, besides experts, technologists, technicians and managers and professionals.
- 6) The norms should be that information disseminated by mass media and their programmes is to be positive. They should be pro-communal harmony, anti-environmental pollution, support national integration, anti-drug addiction, advocate health care and safety, demonstrate benefits of yogic exercises for healthy life, create peace for economic prosperity, anti-terrorism and social evils, generally educative and instructive, giving helpful guidance to children and young adults, etc. If mass media are to become credible instruments of social change, they have to function with restraints and responsibility in accordance with established regulations, codes, conventions and practices.
- 7) The components of mass media are:
Print Media
Radio Broadcasting
Television
Recordings on such as CD. DVD, etc.
Motion Films
- 8) Generally, the daily newspapers carry news, commentaries and analysis on political, economic, social topics on current events, personalities, feature articles of subjects of current topical interests, general information on weather, business information, share market data and analysis, local programmes and events, sports and games, films and such other topics of public interest. Editorial on current specific topics are a daily feature, except on Sundays, which have a very special value as they express views and comments in consonance with the general policy of the newspaper.

- 9) Periodicals and magazines carry feature articles of lasting value, depicting social issues, contributed by eminent writers. They are in almost all Indian languages with wide circulations. There are also special periodicals on health, music, business and trade, sports and games, religion and spirituality and in many other subjects of public interest. Their archival value is much more than newspapers. Therefore they are indexed in secondary periodicals, besides being stored and preserved in libraries. These are some of the reasons for their preservation in libraries.
- 10) Radio broadcasting is able to survive the competition of TV for the following reasons:
 - Radio has larger audience reach than TV because the transistor set can be carried to any place for listening, even to remote places.
 - Radio sets are much cheaper than TV sets which poor people can afford.
 - Radio stations broadcast programmes for every occupational group like farmers, traders, groups of students, women, children and youth, of their respective interests.
 - Radio stations running commentary of events in sports and games which could be listened to from anywhere.
 - Radio broadcast news, music and such other programmes round the clock.
- 11) Recordings refer to audio, video and audio-visual reproductions on magnetic tapes or discs and on laser tapes. They are all part of home archives of radio stations. The home archives of radio stations have stocked a very large number of recorded cassettes and CDs, of speeches of eminent persons, programme events, music, etc. These sources provide invaluable source materials for contemporary and historical studies.
- 12) Television channels, cable TV and recordings are audio-visual media that are so captivating that make people glue to them. Round the clock programmes, choice of channels, suitable timings to watch the recordings, choice of CDs and DVDs for people through cable operators are some of the attractive features of these media. Live telecasts of events and activities through TV channels keep people informed instantaneously, irrespective of their happenings anywhere in the world. So many specialised TV channels operate on various subjects operate round-the-clock giving incomparable opportunities to know about things. No wonder that this electronic form is much more powerful in influencing people than the other forms.
- 13) Films are on all themes of public interest, highly imaginative and mostly unreal. They deal with various aspects that appeal to the masses. Advances in ICT help in bringing most thrilling shows, which can be seen in theaters as well as in TV channels, cable TV, or at home through CDs, etc. All these factors make the films quite different from other forms of mass media.
- 14) The limitations are that access to the Internet is restricted only to those who have access to computers with broadband facilities for using it for their information and knowledge, apart from barriers of illiteracy in India. This

barrier is referred to as *Digital Divide* which practically denies the opportunity to access information to a major section of the community because of economic constraints or illiteracy.

- 15) Mobile phones or cell phones are long-range, electronic devices used for voice or data communication over a network of specialised base stations known as cell sites. In addition to the standard voice function of a mobile phone, current mobile phones support many additional services and accessories such as Short Message Service (SMS) for text messaging, e-mail, access to the Internet and many more. Similar to the Internet, mobile phone is also an interactive media and has a wide reach. Practically all the Internet services and applications that exist have similar facilities on mobile phones.
- 16) Advertisements provide substantial support to all mass media and vice versa. They are so intimately connected to each other that they cannot be separated. As a result, advertising companies are highly research oriented and supported by the corporate sector to initiate highly imaginative advertisements to sell their product and services. The mass media is the best medium for them to publish their products and services which occupy a major share of pages in print media and shown during prime time by TV channels. No programme, either on TV or radio broadcasting is advertisement free.
- 17) Public Relations is deliberate, planned and sustained effort to establish and maintain mutual understanding between the organisation and the public.
- 18) Mass media has to maintain the best of relations with advertising agencies that provide massive support to mass media finances. Apart from this vital necessity, mass media has to constantly assess the impact of their programmes on the audiences. Their message may have to be revised or adjusted to be in tune with the audiences preference. The PR officers will play a vital role in establishing the best relations with all those concerned.
- 19) In the Indian scenario, all the components of mass media function quite well. The newspapers and periodicals are the oldest, followed by films, radio, recordings and TV channels. The media have tremendous influence on the society and it is well reflected in the life of the people. They have both positive and negative influence on the society. While the print media is operating within many constraints, radio and TV have greater penetrations in the society.
- 20) Both Films Library of the Films Division and The National Films Archives of India have large and fine collections of Indian and international films which form a great treasure about Indian culture and Indian art. They offer a variety of services, making use of their collections.
- 21)
 - Mass media operate in a highly commercial and competitive environment;
 - This enjoins quality assurance on the products and services created/generated by mass media;
 - Newspapers, periodicals, TV and radio programmes and many other media product of mass media have to operate within a strict time frame;

- This important factor necessitates that some of the media persons have to perform at great speed without compromising on quality; this accentuates their source credibility;
- The time element necessitates the media persons to keep their information ready for use at a short notice;
- Media work is a teamwork and every participant in them should fit into the team at the right place, the output is a common objective;
- Media persons' expertise, experience and knowledge never get properly recorded and hence is not easily available.

7.13 KEYWORDS

Forth Estate	:	The mass media other than the constitutional powers, like the legislative, executive and the judiciary of a state that wields influence in the political affairs of a country in protecting and safeguarding the rights and interests of the people of the country.
Masses	:	In today's context, 'mass' includes every section of the society, irrespective of their status or knowledge perceptions. Apart from laypersons, they include a wide audience of scholars, professionals, scientists, artists, musicians, in fact, every group, young and old.
Mass Media	:	Mass media is defined "as the institutions of public communication that have as their physical channel of transmission a mass medium – television, radio, motion pictures, newspapers, books, music and recordings".
Media Persons	:	A host of specialists and experts of different professions functioning in mass media.
Multimedia	:	Seamless integration of text, image and sound in a digital environment.
Recordings	:	Recordings here refer to audio, video and audio-visual reproductions on magnetic tapes or discs and on laser tapes.

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